

If on a winter's night a traveler



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ITALO CALVINO

Although he is of Italian heritage, Italo Calvino was born in a suburb of Havana, Cuba, because his father worked for the Mexican government in the Ministry of Agriculture and later moved to Cuba to continue his botanical research. Calvino's mother was also a botanist and a university professor. Soon after Calvino's birth, the family moved back to Italy. In his early life, Calvino's interest in stories made him different from his scientifically inclined parents, but he sympathized with his family's hatred of Italy's fascist government. During World War II, Calvino studied agriculture at university to please his family, but his true interest was writing plays. After going into hiding to avoid fascist military service and later joining the Italian Resistance to fight Nazis and their Italian collaborators, he began writing more seriously. His early novels were realistic and unlike the experimental works he would later become famous for. *The Cloven Viscount* (1952) was Calvino's first novel to include elements of fantasy, and he achieved even more success in 1957 with *The Baron in the Trees* and in 1959 with *The Nonexistent Knight*, which together make up a trilogy called *Our Ancestors*. Over the course of his career, Calvino wrote a variety of short fiction, essays, poems and even opera librettos, but he remains best known for two novels that he published relatively late in his life: *Invisible Cities* (1974) and *If on a winter's night a traveler* (1979). Calvino died suddenly after a stroke in September 1985 while preparing to give a series of lectures, and his lecture notes were published posthumously, along with some of his other autobiographical works.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Calvino's disdain for censorship and government oppression stemmed from his experience living under the National Fascist Party in Italy, which ruled the country from 1922 until 1943, shortly after the Allied Invasion in World War II, when the Fascist leader Benito Mussolini was deposed and imprisoned. Soon after, German special forces rescued Mussolini and installed him as the leader of a state in northern Italy, where he ruled a Nazi puppet state for a couple years until finally a group of Communist and antifascist partisans managed to capture and execute him. Calvino's strong opposition to Mussolini led him to embrace Communist and Marxist views. He began to reject some of his previous Communist views after the Soviet Invasion of Hungary, when the Soviet Union violently invaded Hungary to stop protesters. Nevertheless, Calvino maintained an interest in leftist political views, meeting with the Marxist revolutionary Che Guevara in Cuba in 1964 and living in Paris

during the cultural revolution of May 1968, when student-led protests evolved into nationwide strikes and the near-collapse of the government. Additionally, Calvino himself was experiencing perhaps his greatest period of international fame after the publication of *Invisible Cities* in 1972, and so his constant references to translation in *If on a winter's night a traveler* may have been inspired by the increasing number of readers who were encountering his books in languages other than his native Italian (as well as the fact that both Calvino and his wife worked at various times as translators).

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Calvino credited the Italian writer Cesare Pavese (*The Moon and the Bonfires*) as one of his earliest influences that inspired him to write. Pavese's works are generally more realistic than Calvino's, but the two writers shared similar political views, and Pavese also managed to avoid service in the fascist army during World War II. Another major influence on Calvino was Franz Kafka (*The Metamorphosis*, *Amerika*, *The Trial*), who was famous for writing paranoid stories about ordinary people facing the crushing power of bureaucracy. Kafka's influence is most noticeable in the parts of *If on a winter's night a traveler* involving government censorship of books. For this novel in particular, Calvino cited the influence of Vladimir Nabokov (*Lolita*, *The Pale Fire*), who was famous for writing books that playfully broke the conventions of the novel to tell stories in new and unusual ways. The novel also directly mentions *One Thousand and One Nights* (also called *Arabian Nights*), a collection of Middle Eastern folktales that is one of the most famous examples of a frame story in literature. Calvino's fragmentary and occasionally surreal style has continued to be an influence on contemporary writers, including David Mitchell (*Cloud Atlas*), Ayşegül Savaş (*Walking on the Ceiling*), and Helen Oyeyemi (*Mr. Fox*).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** If on a winter's night a traveler
- **When Written:** 1970s
- **Where Written:** France and Italy
- **When Published:** 1979
- **Literary Period:** Postmodernism
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Europe and the fictional countries of Ataguitania and Ircania
- **Climax:** The Reader decides to marry Ludmilla.
- **Antagonist:** Mortality, destiny, censorship

- **Point of View:** Various

EXTRA CREDIT

A Weaver of Words. A couple of the stories in *If on a winter's night a traveler* feature characters who read aloud the stories. Calvino's English-language translator, William Weaver, has said that he often read aloud when translating Calvino's work in order to find the right rhythms, even reciting passages for guests at his home to seek advice.

Close Reading. Calvino once said that he wrote by hand and that his handwriting could be so bad that he needed a magnifying glass to see what he had written earlier.



PLOT SUMMARY

The narrator informs you, the Reader, that you're about to read *If on a winter's night a traveler* by Italo Calvino, so you should get ready and find a comfortable position. He warns you that Calvino has a reputation for changing his style from **book** to book, but he reassures you that you should still be able to understand and perhaps even enjoy his new book.

You begin to read *If on a winter's night a traveler*, which involves a mysterious narrator with a suitcase. The narrator seems to be a spy or a criminal, since he is at a remote **train** station trying to secretly swap his suitcase with someone else's and is afraid of being caught. But just as you're at a suspenseful moment in the story, it cuts off due to a printing error, and so you go find the bookseller to see what the problem is.

While at the bookstore to return your book, you meet an attractive young woman named Ludmilla, the Other Reader, who also has a defective copy of the book. The bookseller offers you a Polish novel that he claims will continue the story you're in the middle of reading. You decide to swap phone numbers with Ludmilla in case either of you has any more problems with the book.

As it turns out, the next story you read, *Outside the town of Malbork*, doesn't have anything to do with the first one. It involves a young narrator who is apprehensive about leaving the farming family he lives with because Ponko, the son of a nearby family, has to leave home to save himself from a blood feud his family has with a rival family. This story also ends abruptly.

Frustrated again, you call Ludmilla to see if she's having a similar experience. Instead, Ludmilla's sister Lotaria answers the phone. You're disappointed, but then Ludmilla finally answers the phone herself. You and Ludmilla go to a university to find Professor Uzzi Tuzii and hopefully hear the rest of the story.

Uzzi Tuzii begins telling a story translated from the dead

language of Cimmerian that's called *Leaning from the steep slope*. It contains the diary entries of a narrator who, due to his fascination with the beautiful and mysterious Miss Zwida, seems to accidentally get himself involved in a scheme to break someone out of prison. Eventually, Professor Uzzi Tuzii gets so distracted with explaining the story that you can no longer follow what's happening.

Still at the university, you and Ludmilla go to a seminar on feminism where Lotaria is studying with Professor Galligani, a rival of Uzzi Tuzii's. Lotaria reads you a new story called *Without fear of wind or vertigo*. It involves a narrator in a city that is preparing to be attacked during a period of revolution. At the very end of the story, the narrator realizes that his good friend, Valerian, is secretly holding a death warrant with the narrator's name on it. At that point, Lotaria stops the story and says everyone in the class should have enough to discuss for the next month.

You decide to go straight to the publishing house to see learn more about the issue, and there you meet Mr. Cavedagna, a small man who seems to be the person the company sends out to fix problems. From him, you learn about the mysterious translator Ermes Marana who deliberately makes counterfeit translations of books that don't resemble the originals at all. Mr. Cavedagna gives you some photocopied pages of a story called *Looks down in the gathering shadow* to read. You start it and see that it is a story about a narrator who is trying to dispose of the body of a man named Jojo, only to be seemingly betrayed by his accomplice Bernadette at the last minute.

You run out of pages in that book, so you go to a café to meet Ludmilla. She's late, so you start on a new book you picked up at the publisher called *In a network of lines that enlace*. It involves a narrator who seems to hear ringing telephones whenever he's out running. One day, he answers a strange telephone and becomes involved in the kidnapping plot of his student Marjorie.

Eventually, you can't read any more because you've become impatient waiting for Ludmilla. She calls you and invites you to her house, but when you arrive, she doesn't seem to be there. You explore the house and learn more about Ludmilla. Eventually she returns, and you talk more about reading. When you leave her again, you take a copy of the book that you think is identical to the one you were just reading, but in fact the title is subtly different: *In a network of lines that intersect*. This story involves a rich, paranoid narrator who collects kaleidoscopes and fakes his own kidnappings for his protection, only to end up accidentally trapped in a room full of mirrors.

Later, the pulp novelist Silas Flannery records some thoughts in his diary in which you, the Reader, appear as a minor figure. People believe that aliens are communicating with him to guide his next novel, but Flannery himself remains skeptical, even though he has been experiencing strange memory-loss issues

recently. Flannery seems to have an almost supernatural power to control the world he lives in, so he sends the Reader away to go read a book called *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon* in order to give Flannery himself a chance to see Ludmilla alone. The new book involves a young man in Japan who is interested in a young woman named Makiko but who ends up getting caught having sex with Makiko's mother, Madam Miyagi.

The focus shifts back to you, the Reader. Before you can read any more of the Japanese story, you land in the country of Ataguitania (in search of Marana), and the authorities confiscate the book because it's banned. You soon meet a woman named Corinna, who reminds you a lot of Lotaria and who claims to have a copy of the book that she can lend you. You get thrown in prison. Corinna seems to be an authority figure there, and she tries to reassure you. Corinna confuses you, since she goes by many other names and seems to have so many jobs, but she also intrigues you, and at one point, the two of you begin having sex. When the two of you are interrupted, you start doing what you were originally supposed to do: reading a story on the computer for a prison experiment.

The story is called *Around an empty grave*, and it involves a narrator named Nacho's quest to find his real mother after the death of his father, the well-known womanizer Don Anastasio Zamora. Eventually, you have to stop reading because the Ataguitanian police are sending you to do a secret mission in the rival country of Ircania. You learn that despite having very different politics, Ircania also believes in censorship. You try to prevent the confiscation of a book by an author called Anatoly Anatolin, but when you arrange a meeting with Anatolin, he only manages to sneak you a few pages before cops rush out and arrest him.

Anatolin's book is called *What story down there awaits its end?* and is about a narrator who seemingly has the power to make parts of the world disappear. You stop in the middle to try to put in requests at a library for all the previous books you haven't finished, but your efforts are unsuccessful. You and seven other readers talk about reading, and one of them happens to mention that ancient stories only end in two ways: with the death of a hero and heroine or with their marriage. Hearing this, you immediately decide to marry Ludmilla. Later, while married, the two of you lie in bed as you begin to finish reading *If on a winter's night a traveler* by Italo Calvino.

and then with the numbered chapters in between them seemingly having their own narrator. These narrators come from different parts of the world and sometimes even have names, like Gritzvi in *Outside the town of Malbork*, Alex Zinnober in *Without fear of wind or vertigo*, Ruedi the Swiss in *Looks down in the gathering shadow*, and Nacho in *Around an empty grave*. Still, more often, the narrator is nameless, and all the narrator characters are united by some common traits that make them blend together: they tend to be younger men who lust after women (while also struggling to communicate with them), suffer from anxiety or paranoia, and end their stories right at a moment when they face danger or even death. Moreover, sometimes even when the narrator is in character, he will sometimes break the fourth wall by addressing "you," possibly referring to you, the character of the Reader, or possibly literally referring to the person currently reading the **book**. With the character of the narrator, Calvino asks questions about the way people read novels, calling attention to how some aspects of reading, like the concept of a narrator, are merely conventions that make less and less logical sense if one looks at them too closely. By showing how elements of a novel like the narrator can be false or misleading, Calvino invites his audience to consider what other aspects of human society might be based on similarly illogical conventions and what the consequences of that are.

You (The Reader) – The narrator frequently addresses "you," and while at the beginning of the novel, it seems at first that he's directly addressing the audience of the **book**, it turns out that "you" (also known as "the Reader") is a very specific character with specific traits. As it turns out, the Reader is a single man who enjoys reading but experiences a string of frustrations where he can never reach the end of a book he starts reading. While on his reading journey to find the end of these stories, the Reader frequently runs into Ludmilla (also known as the "Other Reader") who seems like a potential love interested but who is also never where the Reader expects her to be, showing up late and often communicating from a distance by telephone. The Reader seems to constantly be at the mercy of forces larger than himself, never finding the books he wants and even ending up in prison near the end of the novel. This prison reflects how reading itself can be a linear process, with a reader having no choice but to follow the path that the author provides. While Calvino's character of you, the Reader, is in some ways an everyman figure, without a name and with a sense of curiosity that feels universal, the Reader ultimately challenges the idea of a unified reading audience, as he reads stories in conditions that are far from ideal for reading and meets other characters along the way who have their own strong, conflicting opinions about how to read, showing that there is no such thing as a universal "you."

Ludmilla (The Other Reader) – Aside from you (the Reader) and the narrator, Ludmilla is the character who appears most



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

The Narrator – In a novel full of fragments and shifting stories, the one constant presence is the narrator. In one sense, the novel seems to have at least 11 different narrators, with each of the 10 titled stories having a different narrator character,

frequently in the numbered chapters that give this fragmented novel its overarching narrative. At first, Ludmilla is merely another person interested in reading the same **books** as the Reader. Over time, however, her distinct personality traits become more prominent. Ludmilla lives alone and has a large wall of books that seems at first to keep the outside world away. In fact, however, Ludmilla gets frequent visits from Irnerio and has a mysterious relationship with the counterfeit translator Ermes Marana, who stays at Ludmilla's house for a while during his travels around the world. Ludmilla, who reads books without knowing what to expect, is the opposite of her sister Lotaria, who reads from a very academic perspective and already has strong expectations before she starts a book. The Reader constantly thinks he sees signs of Ludmilla even while she's absent, but he isn't sure if it's really her or if his perception is just skewed by his love for her. Although Ludmilla seems to like the Reader, she is evasive, and he seems to constantly chase her only to barely miss her. Ultimately, the similar interests of the Reader and Ludmilla bring them to have sex, "reading" each other's bodies, and they later get married.

Lotaria – Lotaria is the sister of Ludmilla, and she is very similar to Corinna—who is possibly even Lotaria disguise, although Corinna's identity remains a mystery. Unlike Ludmilla, Lotaria is a highly methodical reader, always going into a **book** with strong preconceived ideas about what she wants to get from it. This is reflected in the fact that Lotaria is active in seminars at a local university taught by Professor Galligani, where they often read only a short fragment of a book before spending the rest of the month discussing its meaning in highly theoretical terms. The Reader is sometimes tempted by Lotaria, and he has sex with Corinna in part because she reminds him of Lotaria, but ultimately, Lotaria and Corinna are just temptations that keep the Reader away from Ludmilla, who is a better match for him. Lotaria represents the dangers of overanalyzing a book and of taking too academic of a perspective, showing how theory can cause people to get too set in their opinions and expectations—and perhaps can even cause them to miss what a book is really about.

Ermes Marana – Ermes Marana is a counterfeit translator who claims to translate the works of Silas Flannery. In reality, however, Marana may be translating other **books** instead or perhaps inventing new books from scratch for the translations he is hired to do. Marana is a mysterious figure that the Reader hears a lot about—he's always at the center of conspiracies and travels around the world to avoid being found. Marana also has an unusual relationship with Ludmilla, at one point conducting his work out of her house, which causes the Reader to become jealous. Many aspects of Marana's character are deliberately unknown or confusing—in the letters that he writes to his publisher Mr. Cavedagna, he seems to break the flow of time and refer to events that happen in the future. Marana represents the difficulties of translation and how it is a

mysterious process where an author typically has to trust the translator not to print something totally false. Like many other characters, Marana raises questions about the role of the author, showing how forces of chaos like Marana can change the content and meaning of a book on its way from the author to a reader.

Silas Flannery – Silas Flannery is perhaps the most developed of all the fictional writers within the novel, with *In a network of lines that enlace* supposedly being from one of his novels and *In a network of lines that intersect* supposedly being a fraudulent novel by the false translator Ermes Marana. It's also possible that the reverse is true—or even that both novels are fraudulent. Flannery becomes the narrator in Chapter Eight, which consists of a series of his diary entries, including one where the Reader comes to visit him. Although Flannery writes pulp detective novels that don't have a high literary reputation, a sort of cult forms around him, with some believing that his next book will actually be the words of extraterrestrials that transmit thoughts to his brain. Like the character of Italo Calvino, Silas Flannery highlights both how authors and their intentions can get separated from a **book** once it's out in the world with readers (who bring their own perspectives) while also showing how the persona of an author can act like a character, influencing how people read a book—even if it's not how the author intended it.

Uzzi Tuzii – Uzzi Tuzii is a professor specializing in the literature of Cimmeria who attempts to help the Reader and Ludmilla track down a story. Uzzi Tuzii has an ongoing feud with Professor Galligani, who has very different ideas about Cimmerian literature. Although the Reader is initially enthralled with the story that Uzzi Tuzii tells him, paradoxically, as Uzzi Tuzii gets more familiar with the story, it becomes less interesting to hear because he gets bogged down in minor details about the language. Uzzi Tuzii is one of many characters in the novel who represent the dangers of overanalyzing a **book**, which can take away from the pleasure of a story by making it too complicated to understand.

Irnerio – Irnerio is a young man who never reads but who nevertheless maintains a friendship with the avid reader Ludmilla, borrowing her **books** to use for his art projects. Irnerio's secret for never reading isn't to avoid books but the opposite: he looks at them so much that he ceases to actually read what the words say. Irnerio is in some ways the opposite of the Reader, and his ongoing project to turn books into physical art provides a cautionary tale about how some people only care about the aesthetics or lifestyle associated with books without actually bothering to pay attention to what the books are about.

Italo Calvino – Italo Calvino is both the real author of *If on a winter's night a traveler*, as well as a character within that novel who has written a novel called *If on a winter's night a traveler*, which the Reader only sees a small portion of (if he sees it at all

due to a printer error). In addition to being a playful joke, Calvino's inclusion of himself in the novel shows how an author's persona can affect the reading experience, suggesting that all authors characters in their novels to some extent.

Mr. Cavedagna – Mr. Cavedagna is a publishing employee that the Reader runs into when he tries to investigate a printing error in Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler*.

Cavedagna's slight, unimpressive stature indicates that the publishing industry is not the grand romantic business that the Reader was expecting. Mr. Cavedagna shows the human side of **books** and how, despite the authority they seem to hold, they are made by fallible, regular humans.

Corinna – Corinna is a character with many different names and identities. The Reader meets her during his trip to Ataguitania. She reminds the Reader of Lotaria, and they may even be the same person. The Reader can't help being fascinated by Corinna, even having sex with her at one point, but he later feels guilty about having abandoned Ludmilla, who he believes is his true love.

Madam Miyagi – Madam Miyagi is the mother of Makiko, and she has a strained relationship with Makiko's father, Mr. Okeda. In *On a carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*, the family has a young man staying with them (the narrator), and Madam Miyagi seems to flirt with him. This culminates in them having sex, with both Makiko and Mr. Okeda witnessing the act.

The Woman Who Sells Suitcases – There is a nameless woman that the narrator meets in *If on a winter's night a traveler*. All the narrator knows about her is that she is Dr. Marne's ex-wife and that she has a store where she sells suitcases. The narrator of the story seems to be involved in some sort of espionage or crime involving an exchange of suitcases, and this woman recognizes the narrator's suitcase, suggesting she may be somehow in on the conspiracy.

Ponko – Ponko is the son of Mr. Kauderer the farmer who swaps places with the narrator of *Outside the town of Malbork*. He and the narrator are each reluctant about this swap for various reasons, with Ponko not wanting to leave behind his sweetheart, Zwida Ozkart (whom he carries a photo of), and the narrator resentful that Ponko seems destined to replace him in his family.

Mr. Okeda – Mr. Okeda is the father of Makiko, and he has a strained relationship with Makiko's mother, Madam Miyagi. He teaches the narrator in *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*. One day, he sees the narrator having sex with Madam Miyagi, but rather than getting angry, Mr. Okeda seems determined just to pretend it never happened.

Mr. Kauderer the Farmer – There are multiple characters called Mr. Kauderer in the **book**, and the first one is a farmer in the story *Outside the town of Malbork*. He sends his son Ponko to live with a new family and takes in the narrator in place of his son, all to protect Ponko from a violent feud between the

Ozkart and Kauderer families.

Bookseller – A bookseller helps the Reader and Ludmilla after they both realize that there is a printing error in their copies of Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler*. The bookseller helps teach the Reader that despite the air of authority **books** have, they aren't infallible objects, since they are still made and sold by humans.

Chief Gorin – Chief Gorin is a police chief in the bar by the **train** station in *If on a winter's night a traveler*. When he tells the narrator a secret password, the narrator isn't sure whether the police chief is involved in his conspiracy or whether someone has turned the narrator over to the authorities—and the story ends before this mystery can be fully resolved.

Mr. Kauderer the Meteorologist – The second Mr. Kauderer in the story (after Mr. Kauderer the farmer) is a meteorologist who works at an observatory in *Leaning from the steep slope*. He asks the narrator to help him record some weather data while he's away, but soon after he leaves, the narrator realizes Mr. Kauderer may be involved in a conspiracy and seems to be fleeing sinister people who are looking for him.

Miss Zwida – The second character named Zwida in the **book** (after Zwida Ozkart) is a woman who sits on a chair outside a hotel and reads in *Leaning from the steep slope*. She seems to use the narrator's interest in her as a way to get the narrator involved in her plan to break an inmate out of the local prison.

Franziska – Franziska is the woman that the narrator of *What story down there awaits its end?* seems to love, but he only ever likes to run into her by chance. She reveals how this narrator's fears of a deeper relationship make him keep other people at a distance—at the end of the story, a literal chasm between the narrator and Franziska symbolizes this fear.

Faustino Higuera – Faustino Higuera is the brother of Anacleto Higuera. In the past, he fought with Don Anastasio Zamora, the father of Nacho (narrator of *Around an empty grave*). Although Faustino supposedly died during this fight, his grave is empty, and he seems to come back to fight the narrator in a twist that isn't explained before the story fragment ends.

Valerian – Valerian is a friend of the narrator of *Without fear of wind or vertigo*. In the middle of a threesome involving the narrator, Valerian, and Irina, the narrator gets away and sees that Valerian is holding a signed death warrant for the narrator, but the story abruptly ends before anything can come of it.

Arkadian Porphyrich – Arkadian Porphyrich is the director of the State Police Archives in Ircania. The Reader ends up having a discussion with him about censorship, in which Arkadian Porphyrich, who highly supports censorship, says that there is something called "the Spirit" that unites people around the world who believe in nationalism and repression.

Jan – In *If on a winter's night a traveler*, Chief Gorin tells the narrator that someone named Jan has been killed, and later, in

the next story *Outside the town of Malbork*, a character is introduced as Jan's widow. This creates a dreamlike connection between the two stories which are otherwise not directly related in terms of plot, setting, and characters.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Bernadette – Bernadette is the accomplice of the narrator of *Looks down in the gathering shadow*, as the two of them try to dispose of the body of Jojo. At the end of the story, she seems to betray the narrator, although an abrupt ending leaves things unresolved.

Don Anastasio Zamora – Don Anastasio Zamora is the dead father of Nacho, the narrator of *Around an empty grave*. He was a notorious womanizer, and he supposedly killed Faustino Higuera. His death leaves behind many unanswered questions for his son, who seems destined to keep becoming more and more like his father.

Ukko Ahti – Ukko Ahti was a Cimmerian poet who wrote *Leaning from the steep slope*. Eventually, he fell into depression because of his writer's block and killed himself, paralleling the deep writer's block that plagues later writer Silas Flannery.

Anacleto Higuera – Anacleto Higuera is the sister of Faustino Higuera, the mother of Amaranta, and the most likely mother of Nacho, the narrator of *Around an empty grave*. She scolds the narrator for being too much like his father (Don Anastasio Zamora), a destiny that Nacho seems unable to avoid.

Makiko – Makiko is the daughter of Mr. Okeda and Madam Miyagi in *On a carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*. The narrator is attracted to her, but he ends up ruining a potential relationship when he has sex with Madam Miyagi and Makiko witnesses the act.

Zwida Ozkart – Zwida Ozkart is a girl in *Outside the town of Malbork* who seems to be the sweetheart of Ponko (who keeps her photo with him), even though their two families have a blood feud. Seeing Zwida's photo, the narrator is jealous of Ponko.

Anatoly Anatolin – Anatoly Anatolin is the author of *What story down there awaits its end*. Arkadian Porphyrich targets his work for censorship, inspiring the Reader to try to reach Anatolin first. They meet, but Anatolin can only give the Reader some of his work before men pop out to arrest him.

Brigd – Brigd is a woman in *Outside the town of Malbork* whom the narrator seems to love, although he never expresses it. The narrator gets jealous when he imagines that Ponko will get to be with Brigd after the narrator leaves.

Dr. Marne – Dr. Marne is the ex-husband of the woman who sells suitcases in *If on a winter's night a traveler*. He often comes to a bar near a **train** station even though he knows his ex-wife will be there.

Jojo – Jojo is a man that Ruedi the Swiss, the narrator of *Looks down in the gathering shadow*, had to kill for unexplained reasons. Disposing of Jojo's body drives most of that story's plot.

Professor Galligani – Professor Galligani is a rival of Professor Uzzi Tuzii at the university and teaches a seminar that Lotaria attends. Despite his very different views from Uzzi Tuzii, he also gets bogged down in lots of theory when he reads.

Irina – Irina is a woman that the narrator meets in *Without fear of wind or vertigo*. She unites the narrator and Valerian, but her true allegiances to either the revolutionaries or the counterrevolutionaries in the story remain mysterious.

Marjorie – Marjorie is a student of the narrator of *In a network of lines that enlase* who gets kidnapped and tied up.

Amaranta – Amaranta is the daughter of Anacleto Higuera and possibly the sister of Nacho, the narrator of *Around an empty grave*. Nacho starts trying to have sex with her, perhaps to provoke a reaction and get his mother to reveal her identity.

Lorna – Lorna is the mistress of the narrator of *In a network of lines that intersect*. The narrator organizes fake kidnappings to protect himself, but when he gets kidnapped for real (by his wife, Elfrida), he finds Lorna tied up in a room full of mirrors.

Doña Jazmina – Doña Jazmina is the mother of Jacinta and another possible mother of Nacho, the narrator of *Around an empty grave*, but she sends him away and denies that she gave birth to him.

Jacinta – Jacinta is the daughter of Doña Jazmina. As with Amaranta, Nacho, the narrator of *Around an empty grave*, tries to have sex with her, hoping that his attempt will cause his mother to reveal her identity.

Elfrida – Elfrida is the wife of the narrator of *In a network of lines that intersect*. She tries to protect him by pretending to kidnap him but seems to end up trapping both of them in a hall of mirrors.

Tazio Bazakbhal – Tazio Bazakbhal is a Polish novelist who wrote *Outside the town of Malbork*.

Calixto Bandera – Calixto Bandera is the author of *Around an empty grave*, a **book** that Corinna has.

Bertrand Vandervelde – Bertrand Vandervelde is the Belgian author of *Looks down in the gathering shadow*.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



THE ACT OF READING

Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* constantly draws attention to the act of reading a **book**, referencing itself within the story and even including Italo Calvino as a minor character. Fittingly enough, the main character in the novel is "the Reader," whom the narrator also addresses as "you." While the novel seems at first to be breaking the fourth wall and addressing the real-world audience directly, the narration eventually reveals that the "you" in the story is actually a specific character—a single man who gets obsessed with reading stories from beginning to end and whose actions are often driven by attractive women he meets (like Ludmilla, the Other Reader). This is just one of many ways that Calvino draws attention to the typical conventions of novels, showing how authors may act like they're writing for an audience of everyone, when in fact their books presume a very specific audience (often of heterosexual males, like the "you" in the story).

Indeed, more the novel goes on, the more it seems to surprise the audience and perhaps frustrate expectations, refusing to provide closure on any of its 10 stories-with-a-story and leaving open other mysteries as well. In the titular first story, *If on a winter's night a traveler*, the narrator points out that the **train** station he's at is only a carefully structured illusion—and that nothing exists outside the train station or even inside it unless the book specifically mentions it. While some novels, perhaps of the kind that the fictional pulp crime writer Silas Flannery might write, seem to offer a conventionally ordered reading experience with a beginning, middle, and end, Calvino pulls back the curtain to show the audience the inner workings of a novel and how many readers accept the conventions of a novel without considering them. Calvino doesn't do this to belittle the practice of reading but instead to show the potential of all the things a reader can see as well as why it can be limiting to just blindly accept the conventions of a novel. Although Calvino encourages viewing the novel through new eyes, he also references older works like the *Arabian Nights*, showing how his "new" ideas about the fragmentary nature of reading have old roots in history. In *If on a winter's night a traveler*, Calvino crafts a fragmented story that deliberately forces the audience to see the limits of the novel as a medium. At the same time, he uses these fragments to celebrate the diversity of what a novel can be, particularly once people look past the usual conventions of the form.



ACADEMIA AND PUBLISHING

Much of *If on a winter's night a traveler* takes place in locations frequently associated with **books**, like a bookstore, a university, and a publishing house. The novel explores not just books themselves but also the culture surrounding them, which both academia and the publishing

industry greatly influence. While an experimental novel like *If on a winter's night a traveler* might seem like a natural fit for an academic setting, in fact the book is fairly critical of universities and literary theory. Unlike the Reader and the Other Reader, who read mostly out of personal interest and to be surprised or entertained, the student Lotaria only reads books to confirm the truth about something she's already looking for. The seminar she's part of at the university only reads a small fragment of the book before discussing it in abstract terms for the rest of the month. Similarly, Professor Uzzi-Tuzii gets so bogged down in the explaining the details of the Cimmerian language that it eventually becomes impossible to follow his story. These attitudes toward literature demonstrate the limits of reading from a strictly academic perspective.

Similarly, the book's portrayal of the publishing industry also calls into question traditional ideas about the importance of novels. As the Reader learns from his experience buying books with printing errors from the bookseller, it's easy for a publishing mistake to totally change the author's intention. Furthermore, the publishing house that the Reader visits seems to be in a constant state of chaos. Amid this chaos, the publisher ends up publishing counterfeit translations by Ermes Marana that don't even resemble the original books. And in the process of doing so, the publisher gives these fakes an air of legitimacy. And so, just as Calvino draws attention the interior workings of a novel, he also explores the external aspects of a novel's creation and how the people involved in publishing and bookselling are fallible humans who can influence the process. While Calvino's harsh criticisms of academia and the publishing industry may be partly affectionate, they ultimately encourage his audience to be skeptical of traditional sources of wisdom and instead attempt to approach books without any preconceived ideas.



CENSORSHIP AND GOVERNMENT OPPRESSION

Italo Calvino had firsthand experience with government oppression, living through the reign of the fascist government of Benito Mussolini in Italy, and later opposing the harsh rule of Joseph Stalin and his immediate successors in the Soviet Union. This likely explains why the various story fragments within *If on a winter's night a traveler* often contain elements of paranoia, evoking fears of surveillance and punishment, with some making direct reference to totalitarian governments. The most straightforward instance of government oppression comes in the final few chapters, when you (the Reader) are imprisoned in Ataguitania, a country that bans books, only to be sent later on secret mission to Ircania, a country with a totally different political situation that ends up banning different books for a different reason.

Although characters like Corinna and Arkadian Porphyrich try

to emphasize how humane their prisons are and why the policy of book banning makes sense, the Reader can see the absurdity of his situation and how hypocritical those characters are. Arkadian Porphyrich considers himself part of a movement, which he calls “the Spirit,” that crosses national and ideological boundaries. But his seemingly hopeful declaration of unity has sinister undertones, suggesting that in many diverse nations and ideologies there is the danger of people who blindly submit to authority, enacting censorship and oppression without understanding why. Throughout the novel, Calvino depicts other menacing characters who also seem to have “the Spirit” of oppression, like the men from Section D in *What story down there awaits its end?* who are capable of making parts of the world disappear at will or the narrator of *In a network of lines that intersect*, who is so obsessed with safety that he ends up trapping himself. And so, in *If on a winter's night a traveler*, Italo Calvino celebrates the power of reading by showing how determined some people are to control books through censorship. In so doing, Calvino also satirizes oppressive regimes by showing how they can use benign language to hide cruelty and hypocrisy.



LOVE, LUST, AND ANXIETY

While the main plot of Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* involves the quest of a fictional you, the Reader, to complete reading the fragments of

books that you find, this plot is closely connected to a growing love story between the Reader and Ludmilla (the Other Reader). On the one hand, the novel explores lust, with many of the various story fragments following the perspective of men who make bad decisions due to their attraction to women they encounter. In one story, for instance, the narrator ruins a potential relationship with the young woman Makiko, all because he recklessly has sex with her mother, Madam Miyagi, right in the middle of their house, where everyone sees them. In many ways, the lust of the narrator characters reflects the desires and anxieties of the Reader, who struggles to make sense of his feelings for Ludmilla and how these feelings connect back to his desire to keep reading more stories. This is because much of the Reader's quest to continue reading stories is actually driven by his desire to keep finding excuses to talk to Ludmilla.

Ultimately, though, the force that motivates the Reader to finally overcome his neuroses and marry Ludmilla is an even deeper anxiety: the fear of death. Many of the book's stories end with a character on the brink of death. In *Without fear of wind or vertigo*, for instance, the narrator discovers his own death warrant or *Around an empty grave*, where Faustino Higuera is about to attack Nacho with a knife. The Reader wants to avoid himself facing the grim fate that these characters—whom he identifies with—seem like they're about to face. And so, the Reader's marriage to Ludmilla suggests that

a genuine, loving connection can provide stability and comfort (or at least the illusion of these things) in an otherwise alienating, fragmented, and anxiety-inducing world. While *If on a winter's night a traveler* portrays how anxiety and lust can be barriers to forming a close relationship, the novel nevertheless offers hope that people who “read” the world in similar ways might somehow find each other, and that these connections might offer a sense of stability and at least a temporary cure for universal human anxieties.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



BOOKS

Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* is a book about books, and in it, books symbolize

knowledge—specifically how the truth can appear simple on the surface but becomes complicated and fragmented upon closer inspection. When the Reader picks up a copy of Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler*, he is expecting an orderly reading experience and a story with a conventional beginning and ending. However, a printing error cuts off the story, and this causes the Reader to wonder whether he was ever actually reading Calvino's book to begin with. The Reader's journey takes him across many places associated with books, including a bookstore, a university, a home with a personal book collection, and a censorship office. In these various locations, the Reader meets people with a variety of reading styles. For example, while Ludmilla is a voracious reader who likes to be surprised by her books, her sister Lotaria reads more slowly, taking a more academic, theoretical approach and always having strong ideas about what she expects a book to be before she reads it.

Over the course of the novel, the Reader starts but can't finish 10 different novels, with various circumstances conspiring to stop him from ever reading an ending. This suggests that the modern world is full of information and distractions. It also suggests that every reader will encounter a book under different, specific circumstances, and this can lead to very different reading experiences. Half of the chapters in the novel tell a continuous story while the other half consists of fragments that end abruptly, reflecting the dual nature of books: they can be a linear experience with a beginning and end, but they can also be messier and less orderly. Ultimately, while Calvino celebrates the process of reading in all its messiness, he challenges the idea that books provide closure or authoritative knowledge, showing how even the concept of truth can become difficult to pin down when each reader has their own perspective on the world.



TRAINS

The trains that appear in this novel, most prominently in the titular *If on a winter's night a traveler*, symbolize how reading is a journey that can transport readers to new and unexpected places. In particular, the train symbolism portrays reading as a linear, guided experience—at least on the surface. The titular story focuses on a nameless narrator who has somehow arrived at a remote train station but seems reluctant to reveal anything about his identity, why he came to the train station, or what he did before arriving at the station. The narrator constantly points out how the world around him is an illusion and how you, the Reader, can only see something if the author specifically points out to you. These details all call attention to how a reader, like a train, is on a guided set of tracks laid by the author and has no option but to move forward, observing the lives of characters who also move on defined tracks.

Still, as the rest of the novel makes clear, just because reading is a linear experience doesn't mean a story must be a straightforward journey from beginning to end. The train in the first story might give a sense of continuity and forward momentum, but the abrupt ending of that first story confirms that the novel as a whole will not be a linear train ride. Later in the novel, the Reader is on a train and thinks he glimpses Ludmilla in a train going the opposite way, only to wake up and realize that the whole experience was a dream. Shortly after, the Reader marries Ludmilla, contradicting the dream of the opposite trains and suggesting that, as much as trains seem like powerful forces moving in a single direction, sometimes the notion of a linear journey is little more than an illusion.

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

These lines begin *If on a winter's night a traveler*, immediately introducing the book's unusual structure, which features a narrator character talking directly to "you," the Reader. Initially, the Reader appears to be a surrogate for the audience, with the narrator breaking the fourth wall to speak directly to whoever is currently reading the book. But as the novel goes on, it becomes clear that, in fact, the Reader is a character with specific traits who will not be someone whom most readers can relate to.

A recurring idea in this novel is how the beginnings of stories can be both disorienting but also full of potential. In many ways, the novel contains almost nothing but beginnings, with 10 different story fragments within the story that each representing a new start. As the Reader becomes a more developed character, he becomes more burdened by anxiety and concerns about his past. This novel challenges the idea that different people experience the same thing when they read a book, and so it ridicules the idea that a book can address every reader, choosing instead to explore the thoughts and experiences of one specific Reader rather than a universal audience.

☞ You prepare to recognize the unmistakable tone of the author. No. You don't recognize it at all. But now that you think about it, who ever said this author had an unmistakable tone? On the contrary, he is known as an author who changes greatly from one book to the next. And in these very changes you recognize him as himself.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Italo Calvino

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 9

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes how the Reader is feeling as he's about to read Italo Calvino, who is the real author of *If on a winter's night a traveler*, but who also appears as a character within that book. This quote describes the real-life career of Italo Calvino (whose works did indeed often vary in style from one to the next) while also describing the style of this current novel, which Calvino wrote but which takes on



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Harcourt edition of *If on a winter's night a traveler* published in 1982.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ You are about to begin reading Italo Calvino's new novel, *If on a winter's night a traveler*. Relax. Concentrate. Dispel every other thought. Let the world around you fade.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Italo Calvino

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

different styles as he adopts various fictional author and translator personas.

This passage suggests how complicated a person's identity can be. The narrator claims that the most consistent aspect of Calvino's style is that it changes from book to book. In fact, although the chapters of this novel differ significantly in style, they also share some significant similarities, such as the way they tend to focus on a young male narrator and his struggles to communicate with the women he knows. This passage suggests that finding the truth in a book ultimately means accepting changes, recognizing that these changes aren't inconsistencies but simply different ways of looking at the truth that nonetheless add up to a more complete picture of all the possible messages a book might convey.

If on a winter's night a traveler Quotes

☞ The novel begins in a railway station, a locomotive huffs, steam from a piston covers the opening of the chapter, a cloud of smoke hides part of the first paragraph.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 10

Explanation and Analysis

This quote begins the first of *If on a winter's night a traveler's* 10 story fragments. As with the previous chapter, the opening lines of this chapter immediately subvert the genre conventions audiences might expect a novel to follow, breaking the typical divide between reader, narrator, and characters by describing steam from a train as covering part of a paragraph. Like the previous chapter, the narrator of this chapter seems to be aware that he's in a story, raising the question of whether these two narrators are different characters or simply different variations on the same character. Ultimately, this distinction is beside the point—as the previous quote notes, all the different styles in this novel are variations on Calvino himself.

Notably, the setting of a train station in this quote signifies how the beginning of this story is a starting point for everything that follows. Trains follow tracks, and like trains, a novel must move forward in time in a linear way. But by breaking the usual conventions of a novel, the narrator also challenges this linear narrative, showing how even though a novel must move forward in time, it can nevertheless

contain ambiguities and stylistic changes that deviate from a strictly linear path.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ And so the Other Reader makes her happy entrance into your field of vision, Reader, or, rather, into the field of your attention; or, rather, you have entered a magnetic field from whose attraction you cannot escape. Don't waste time, then, you have a good excuse to strike up a conversation, a common ground, just think a moment, you can show off your vast and various reading, go ahead, what are you waiting for?

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Bookseller

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the moment when the Reader, while at the bookseller's shop to replace his defective copy of *If on a winter's night a traveler*, first encounters Ludmilla, the other Reader. Reading, while often a solitary activity, also connects people at a distance who happen to be reading the same thing. This passage makes that connection literal, with the Reader and the Other Reader each being defined characters who meet and converse with each other.

The Reader's inability to look away from Ludmilla could be a result of his lust, an emotion that runs throughout the novel, particularly in the male characters. But the Reader's fascination with Ludmilla also suggests his curiosity about Ludmilla's experience reading the same book, *If on a winter's night a traveler*. Due to his love of books, the Reader can't help but wonder if other readers, like Ludmilla, have the same experience as he does. Still, despite everything the Reader has in common with Ludmilla, he struggles to find the right words to approach her. This shows how, for as much as the Reader has learned about the world through his reading, he hasn't learned how to communicate with others in the real world, illustrating the limits of what a book can teach.

Outside the town of Malbork Quotes

☞ Mr. Kauderer shook his head but didn't look her in the face. "He isn't a Kauderer! We're the ones who are in danger, always!"

Related Characters: Mr. Kauderer the Farmer (speaker), The Narrator, Ponko, Zwida Ozkart

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 41

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the end of the chapter, when Mr. Kauderer, a farmer in an unspecified country that may be Poland or the fictional Cimmeria, describes the blood feud between his family and the Ozkarts. In order to protect his son Ponko from the Ozkarts, Mr. Kauderer has arranged for him to swap places with the narrator (whose name is Gritzvi in this story), promising that because the narrator isn't a Kauderer, the Ozkarts won't come after him.

Like all the story fragments in the novel, this one ends with many questions unanswered. The narrator has no way of knowing if Mr. Kauderer is telling the truth or if he is willingly putting the narrator at risk to protect Ponko. This quote also highlights the absurdity of the feud, suggesting that the Kauderers and the Ozkarts aren't fighting over a legitimate perceived wrong or difference of opinion: they're simply fighting over their different surnames—in other words, an arbitrary, single word. And so, this conflict between the families is a microcosm for many of the other conflicts that involve words in the novel. Some of these conflicts play out in political revolutions where the side a person takes can have deadly consequences, while other battles over words take place in an academic setting and have less severe consequences.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ “Me? I don’t read books!” Irnerio says.

“What do you read, then?”

“Nothing. I’ve become so accustomed to not reading that I don’t even read what appears before my eyes. It’s not easy: they teach us to read as children, and for the rest of our lives we remain the slaves of all the written stuff they fling in front of us. I may have had to make some effort myself, at first, to learn not to read, but now it comes quite naturally to me. The secret is not refusing to look at the written words. On the contrary, you must look at them, intensely, until they disappear.”

Related Characters: You (The Reader) , Irnerio (speaker), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Uzzi Tuzii

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 49

Explanation and Analysis

This quote introduces Irnerio, a student at the local university who has taught himself how not to read. Rather than simply avoiding books, as one might expect, instead Irnerio has learned how to not read books by instead looking at them *too* closely.

Irnerio’s unusual philosophy for life is a parody of people who care so much for the appearance of books or the status that they give that they end up ignoring the actual contents of the books. Irnerio’s methods for not reading may also parody how schools teach reading, suggesting that analyzing a book too closely can actually obscure its meaning rather than reveal it. Throughout the novel, Irnerio never seems to receive any punishment for his failure to read and in fact seems to be one of the most cheerful characters. While *If on a winter’s night a traveler* is primarily a celebration of reading, it also asks what people get out of reading (which can cause disappointment and frustration) and whether someone like Irnerio, who refuses to read and thus remains ignorant, can truly be as happy as he seems.

Leaning from the steep slope Quotes

☞ I sensed at once that in the perfect order of the universe a breach had opened, an irreparable rent.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Mr. Kauderer the Meteorologist , Miss Zwida

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 67

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the narrator’s reaction in the story *Leaning from the steep slope* after the narrator runs into an old, bearded man who is presumably an escaped inmate from the local prison. The story fragment ends before the story can explore the consequences of the narrator’s encounter with the escapee, but seeing the bearded man seems to confirm for the narrator that Miss Zwida betrayed him, using the narrator’s trusting nature to attempt to involve him in a prison break. Perhaps the narrator also better understands the behavior of Mr. Kauderer, the meteorologist who went into hiding and made vague references about a rebellion plan to the narrator.

The narrator’s comment suggests that having one’s illusions or viewpoint contradicted can feel as monumental as a tear

in the universe. The quote shows how all the novel's characters have their own ideas about the "order of the universe"—as well as how these ideas might shatter when presented with new information, which is why so many characters fear the unknown. The inability of the narrator to "repair" his old ideas about the universe provide yet another example in the novel of how time inevitably moves forward.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞ The Cimbri-Cimmerian debate does not seem to affect Ludmilla, now occupied with a single thought: the possibility that the interrupted novel might continue.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Lotaria, Uzzi Tuzii, Professor Galligani

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 74

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes an academic disagreement between Professor Uzzi-Tuzii and Professor Galligani about how to classify a body of literature that could belong to the country of Cimmeria or to the country of Cimbria (both of which are fictional). While this debate animates the two professors and seems to be the basis of their careers, Ludmilla totally ignores it, focusing instead on her constant desire to keep reading to see what happens next.

Although Ludmilla's naïve style of reading can have its own limitations, this chapter at the university ultimately criticizes an overly academic approach to literature, suggesting that it can bog readers down in unimportant details. Cimbria and Cimmeria are very similar-sounding names, and the fact that both are fake countries shows just how low the stakes of Uzzi-Tuzii's and Galligani's arguments are. This chapter thus suggests that when a reader approaches a book with rigid expectations for what the book out to say or teach them, they run the risk of misunderstanding the book's messages altogether. This means that Ludmilla's straightforward, if somewhat superficial, strategy of reading a book for its plot may be superior.

Without fear of wind or vertigo Quotes

☞ "The real revolution will be when women carry arms."

Related Characters: Irina (speaker), The Narrator, Lotaria, Uzzi Tuzii, Valerian

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

This is a quote that the revolutionary Irena says to Valerian and the narrator after Valerian chastises Irena for being careless with the gun she's holding. Lotaria is reading this story fragment (*Without fear of wind or vertigo*) aloud in a seminar on feminism, and so it makes sense that this quote addresses a feminist theme.

Despite the potentially feminist themes of this quote, however, it's ambiguous to what extent the quote is a sincere reflection of the novel's themes. Irena is acting unpredictably at this point in the story. Furthermore, the novel portrays the feminist seminar that Lotaria attends somewhat negatively—like Professor Uzzi-Tuzii, seminar participants get too bogged down in academic theories to read a book on its own terms. Still, the quote raises questions about what true equality of the sexes looks like and what type of ideal society a revolution should strive to achieve if it wants to avoid simply repeating the mistakes of the previous government (as many revolutions in this novel ultimately do).

Chapter 5 Quotes

☞ You realize at once that Mr. Cavedagna is that person indispensable to every firm's staff, on whose shoulders his colleagues tend instinctively to unload all the most complex and tricky jobs.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Italo Calvino, Mr. Cavedagna

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 95

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the Reader's impression upon going to the publishing house of Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* to see what the story is behind its printing error. There he meets Mr. Cavedagna, a man who is capable at his job but not particularly impressive. In general, the Reader's

trip to the publisher depresses him, shattering his illusions about books by showing how ordinary the behind-the-scenes work of creating a book can be.

Notably, Ludmilla refuses to go to the publisher with the Reader, stating that there is a sharp divide between author and reader, and that she'll always side with the latter. Like many characters in the novel, Ludmilla remains strategically ignorant in order to keep her worldview intact. By contrast, the ever-curious Reader can't help going in person to investigate how a book really gets made. Calvino punctures some of the authority of books by revealing how mundane the process of creating them really is. At the same time, though, chapter also adds to the mystery of books by showing the effect they can have on readers like Ludmilla and the Reader despite their mundane origins.

Looks down in the gathering shadow Quotes

☛☛ Jojo meanwhile was falling on top of us, but she was careful to push him aside, her face only inches from the face of the dead man, who looked at her with the whites of his widened eyes.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Bernadette, Jojo

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 111

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from *Looks down in the gathering shadow* right after the moment where the narrator and Bernadette finish having sex in a car with while the corpse of Jojo is in the back seat. The narrator and Bernadette have gotten distracted while on a mission to dispose of Jojo's body, and the physically weighty corpse seems to represent all the things in the narrator's past that weigh on his conscience metaphorically.

As this passage shows, lust and sex are forces so powerful that they can even cause a person to forget death, with the narrator and Bernadette barely registering the dead Jojo, even as his corpse "watches" them from the back seat. Jojo's wide eyes, however, seem to hint at how death is always watching and following people. Rather than confronting this anxiety directly, however, the narrator avoids it for the moment with sex—and then plans to continue avoiding it by disposing of Jojo's body. The way that Jojo's corpse intrudes on sex by falling on top of the lovers suggests that, despite the narrator's efforts to avoid thinking about death or his

guilt about his past, the threat of death never ceases to exist. In a broader sense, this indicates that some anxieties are impossible to ignore forever.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☛☛ Ermes Marana appears to you as a serpent who injects his malice into the paradise of reading.

This quote describes the Reader's reaction to first hearing about Ermes Marana, a translator whom the Reader learns about in the publishing house he visits and who seems to have an unusual life full of conspiracy and mystery. Marana has a reputation as a counterfeiter, claiming to translate books but in fact replacing them with translations of totally unrelated books. While the Reader seems to be interested in Marana, unable to stop reading his letters, ultimately the Reader finds Marana disturbing.

By raising the idea that a translation could be an unfaithful copy of the original, Marana destroys the Reader's notion of a book as an act of communication between an author and a reader. Although Marana represents an extreme case, he illustrates how in general, translation can be a tricky job, and even a faithful translator may nevertheless introduce some changes into a book. By refusing to remain ignorant about the book-making process, the Reader, like Ludmilla, finds himself falling down a rabbit hole of questions that make him doubt everything he knows about reading. This reinforces the novel's broader argument about how the truth can be elusive and fragmented.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Ermes Marana, Silas Flannery

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 125

In a network of lines that enlase Quotes

☛☛ It was a mistake to invite her: this was during my first days of teaching, they did not yet know the sort I am here, she could misunderstand my intentions, that misunderstanding in fact took place, an unpleasant misunderstanding, even now very hard to clarify because she has that ironic way of looking at me, and I am unable to address a word to her without stammering, the other girls also look at me with an ironic smile.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Marjorie

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 138

Explanation and Analysis

This comes from the narrator of *In a network of lines that enlase* after he picks up a mysterious ringing telephone and hears that someone named Marjorie has been kidnapped. The narrator thinks back to the Marjorie he knows best, a student of his at the university who seemingly misinterpreted his offer to lend her a book as an attempt at flirtation.

The narrator suffers a lot from the misunderstanding that occurred during this short interaction (assuming it was a misunderstanding—the narrator does indeed find Marjorie attractive). The narrator's fears about being unable to communicate seem to constantly taunt him on his runs when he hears all the ringing telephones. When he answers the mysterious telephone that no one else ever picks up, the narrator perhaps thinks it will allow him to overcome his fear of communication. But instead, he only becomes involved in an even deeper understanding, with Marjorie seemingly accusing him of kidnapping her. This story as a whole explores how anxieties can take shape in reality, with the narrator's inability to confront the root issue of his lust for Marjorie leaving him unable to outrun his anxieties no matter how hard he tries.

Chapter 7 Quotes

☞☞ This book so far has been careful to leave open to the Reader who is reading the possibility of identifying himself with the Reader who is read: this is why he was not given a name, which would automatically have made him the equivalent of a Third Person, of a character (whereas to you, as Third Person, a name had to be given, Ludmilla), and so he has been kept a pronoun, in the abstract condition of pronouns, suitable for any attribute and any action. Let us see, Other Reader, if the book can succeed in drawing a true portrait of you, beginning with the frame and enclosing you from every side, establishing the outlines of your form.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Ludmilla (The Other Reader)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 141

Explanation and Analysis

This quote, which describes the Reader's visit to Ludmilla's house while she's absent, comes right before a temporary shift in the novel's perspective, where the narrator begins to call Ludmilla "you" instead of the reader. The passage draws attention to how the narrator has hidden many aspects of the Reader by always referring to him as "you," while also revealing more about Ludmilla by keeping her at a distance, always referring to her in the third person.

By changing the perspective, the narrator challenges the idea that there is anything particularly interesting about the Reader. The narrator explores how the perspective of a book can privilege a character, giving their experiences an air of importance. While the Reader was never quite a universal figure to begin with, this passage represents a turning point after which the Reader truly becomes a specific character and, in the process, becomes less of a surrogate for real-world readers. Through the narrator, the novel explores its own blind spots, emphasizing what it both gains and loses by focusing on the Reader, whose traditional ideas about reading and whose attraction toward Ludmilla skew his perspective.

In a network of lines that intersect Quotes

☞☞ Maybe this is why I need mirrors to think: I cannot concentrate except in the presence of reflected images, as if my soul needed a model to imitate every time it wanted to employ its speculative capacity.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Lorna, Elfrida

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 161

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the beginning of *In a network of lines that intersect* and describes the wealthy narrator's unusual habit of collecting mirrors, and later kaleidoscopes. The narrator's reliance on mirrors seems to parallel the process of reading, evoking how the Reader, for example, looks for versions of himself in what he reads in order to better understand the world.

The narrator's decision to move on from mirrors to

kaleidoscopes as a way to think reflects how, in the modern world, truth has become fractured and so requires a fractured way of thinking about it. But while the whole novel does indeed depict the truth as fractured, the narrator doesn't seem to benefit from his strategy of thinking with kaleidoscopes. In fact, the narrator of this story slowly descends into a state of paranoia, with the kaleidoscopes perhaps representing how the narrator sees the threats to himself as more numerous than they actually are. By letting his paranoia distract him, the narrator ignores the more tangible potential conflict in his life between his mistress, Lorna, and wife, Elfrida. Ultimately, the kaleidoscopes in this story represent the danger and futility of trying to force a cohesive narrative onto unrelated, fragmented truths.

unreliable translator. As Flannery tells it, the scribe Abdullah lost faith in Mohammad because he believed Mohammad wasn't faithfully conveying the words of Allah to his scribes, particularly when Mohammad accepted a suggestion from his scribe. On the one hand, this story about Mohammad and his scribe could cast doubt on the idea of truth in books, suggesting that even the literal word of God is susceptible to translation errors. But instead, Flannery takes the opposite approach, embracing the flaws of translation as divinely inspired. Flannery's embrace of the chaos the false translator Marana has caused is the opposite approach of Ludmilla's, and the novel leaves open the question of whether it's better to embrace ambiguity like Flannery or to embrace a straightforward approach to reading like Ludmilla.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☞☞ The Koran is the holy book about whose compositional process we know most. There were at least two mediations between the whole and the book: Mohammed listened to the word of Allah and dictated, in his turn, to his scribes. Once—the biographers of the Prophet tell us— while dictating to the scribe Abdullah, Mohammed left a sentence half finished. The scribe, instinctively, suggested the conclusion. Absently, the Prophet accepted as the divine word what Abdullah had said. This scandalized the scribe, who abandoned the Prophet and lost his faith.

He was wrong... The scribe's collaboration was necessary to Allah, once he had decided to express himself in a written text.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader) , Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Hermes Marana, Silas Flannery

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 182

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the diary of Silas Flannery, a writer who exists in the same "real world" as the Reader and Ludmilla (who each appear as minor figures in Flannery's diary). In this passage, Flannery muses on the real story of Islam's founding, where Mohammed collaborated with scribes to create the Koran, a text that Muslims believe is the literal word of Allah.

The creation of the Koran fascinates Flannery because it reminds him of his own experiences with a potentially

☞☞ I have had the idea of writing a novel composed only of beginnings of novels. The protagonist could be a Reader who is continually interrupted. The Reader buys the new novel A by the author Z. But it is a defective copy, he can't go beyond the beginning.

Related Characters: The Narrator, Silas Flannery (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 197

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the diary of Silas Flannery, occurring toward the end of the chapter. In his diary, Flannery describes almost exactly the same premise that Calvino himself arrived at for *If on a winter's night a traveler* (the whole novel, not the story within the novel).

Although Calvino's (the author of the book, not fictionalized Calvino who is a character in the novel) rhetorical choice to break the fourth wall here might suggest that Calvino identifies with Flannery, an earlier entry on Flannery's diary mused on a different story idea where two very different authors somehow ended up writing the same thing. Moreover, the biographical details of Flannery's life are very different from Calvino's—while Flannery is an Irish author writer of pulp fiction, Calvino is an Italian writer of literary fiction. Still, by drawing a comparison between his own work and that of a pulp writer, Calvino suggests that there are universal truths about writing that go beyond national boundaries and the distinction between high and low

culture. Even though an author like Flannery might not have an esteemed literary reputation, Calvino nevertheless emphasizes with many of his struggles, perhaps especially the pressure to remain productive as a writer.

On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon Quotes

☝☝ But the triumph of the water lilies' capture upset the order of our movements, and so my right arm closed over a void, whereas my left hand, which had abandoned its hold on the shoot, fell back and encountered the lap of Madame Miyagi, who seemed prepared to receive it and almost hold it, with a yielding start which was communicated to my whole person. At this moment something was determined that later had incalculable consequences, as I will recount in time.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Madam Miyagi, Mr. Okeda, Makiko

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 202

Explanation and Analysis

This quote from *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon* describes a moment when the narrator reaches down to scoop up a water lily and finds himself flanked on one side by the attractive Makiko and on the other side by her mother, Madame Miyagi. The narrator tries to take this opportunity to secretly grope Makiko's breast, but his efforts backfire when his hand accidentally goes into the lap of Madame Miyagi. As the narrator notes, this is a pivotal moment that determines the course of the rest of the story.

This passage, and the narrator's experience in this story in general, illustrate the dangers of lust and impatience. The narrator's inability to show restraint around Makiko caused him to accidentally grab Madame Miyagi, and a similar impatience later in the story leads to him actually having sex with Miyagi. Ultimately, the narrator's actions show how beneath the refined conversations he has with Mr. Okeda over the beauty of ginkgo leaves, the narrator's intellectual ideas of beauty are far less powerful than the lust that drives him to Miyagi against his better judgment.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☝☝ "I don't understand who you're accusing, I don't know anything about your stories. I follow a very clear strategy. The counterpower must infiltrate the mechanisms of power in order to overthrow it."

"And then reproduce it, identically! It's no use your camouflaging yourself, Lotaria! If you unbutton one uniform, there's always another uniform underneath!"

Related Characters: You (The Reader), Corinna (speaker), Lotaria, Uzzi Tuzii, Professor Galligani

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 218

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is a conversation between Corinna and the Reader that occurs after the Reader has arrived in the fictional country of Ataguitania, had his book confiscated, and been thrown into prison. All the while, Corinna tries to assure the Reader by telling him he's only in a fake prison and that she's only pretending to be part of an oppressive government in order to eventually overthrow it. But the Reader questions what a "fake" prison even means if it looks like and serves the same purpose as a normal, "real" prison.

Similar to the academic arguments between Professor Uzzi-Tuzii and Professor Galligani, this passage illustrates how opposing sides of a heated conflict can end up supporting and perpetuating the very ideas they claim to reject. But while that university conflict mostly dealt in theory, this conflict between revolutionaries and counterrevolutionaries has real political consequences, particularly for people like the Reader who gets caught in the middle. While Calvino's novel is firmly against censorship and government oppression, it also explores the tension of how a rebellion can end up becoming the oppressive force it rebels against.

Around an empty grave Quotes

☝☝ "What gave you the right, Nacho Zamora, to lay your hands on my sister?" he says, and a blade gleams in his right hand.

Related Characters: Faustino Higuera (speaker), The Narrator, Don Anastasio Zamora, Anacleto Higuera, Amaranta, Doña Jazmina, Jacinta

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 233**Explanation and Analysis**

This comes near the end of *Around an empty grave*, a twisting story of a narrator named Nacho's attempt to determine the identity of his true mother, who may be Anacleta Higuera or may be Doña Jazmina. Nacho's journey leads him to the empty grave of Faustino Higuera, a man whom Nacho's father supposedly killed but who suddenly appears and says this quote.

In this quote, Faustino Higuera accuses "Nacho Zamora" of laying hands on his sister, but it isn't clear whom he's referring to because both Nacho (the narrator) and Nacho's father have gone by the name Nacho. Indeed, this raises the question of whether Faustino himself is a younger relative of the old Faustino. As with the feud in an earlier story between the Kauderers and the Ozkarts, this feud between Faustino and Nacho ultimately revolves around a name. This story raises questions of identity across generations, showing how new generations can be doomed to repeat the same mistakes as the generation before them.

to relate to authoritarianism (a political ideology centered on obedience to authority).

As Arkadian Porphyrich shows, the Spirit is a concept that goes beyond ideology and can unite people in different circumstances. The Spirit provides an explanation for how even very different ideologies, like revolutionaries and counterrevolutionaries, can nevertheless both end up being repressive—because they both leave space for the Spirit to grow. While Arkadian Porphyrich speaks of the Spirit in glowing terms, it clearly refers to something more sinister, including the desire to control other people. This passage explores how officials like Arkadian Porphyrich can use euphemistic language to disguise their dangerous, repressive ideas—when in fact they are referring to oppression and censorship.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☞ "I don't know if you believe in the Spirit, sir. I believe in it. I believe in the dialogue that the Spirit conducts uninterruptedly with itself. And I feel that this dialogue is fulfilled as my gaze examines these forbidden pages. The Police is also Spirit, the State that I serve, the Censorship, like the texts on which our authority is exercised. The breath of the Spirit does not require a great audience to reveal itself; it flourishes in the shadow, in the obscure relationship perpetuated between the secrecy of the conspirators and the secrecy of the Police."

Related Characters: Arkadian Porphyrich (speaker), You (The Reader)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 237**Explanation and Analysis**

This quote lays out the life philosophy of Arkadian Porphyrich, a government official who oversees censorship in the (fictional) nation of Ircania, a rival of Ataguitania that nevertheless has some mutually beneficial secret treaties with that country. In this quote, Arkadian Porphyrich refers to an abstract concept that he calls "the Spirit," which seems

What story down there awaits its end? Quotes

☞ On the ground that separates me from Franziska I see some fissures open, some furrows, crevasses; at each moment one of my feet is about to be caught in a pitfall: these interstices widen, soon a chasm will yawn between me and Franziska, an abyss!

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Franziska

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 251**Explanation and Analysis**

This quote comes near the end of *What story down there awaits its end*, the final story fragment in the novel. The nameless narrator, who has the ability to make parts of his world disappear, finds himself confronted by men in overcoats who are even more powerful than him, leaving the narrator to scramble to avoid falling into a chasm.

All of the narrator's problems seemingly arose because he was trying to create the conditions for a random encounter with Franziska, the woman he's attracted to. As the final story fragment of the novel, this fragment fittingly raises the stakes, portraying a man's inability to communicate with a woman as not just a personal tragedy but something that could end the entire world. The gulfs that the narrator attempts to cross on his way to see Franziska dramatically illustrate how difficult it can be to bridge the communication gap between two people. The fracturing earth in this story also reiterates the book's position that the truth has become fractured with multiple perspectives, with the fractured ground in this story recalling the

kaleidoscopes of an earlier story fragment.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☞ “If on a winter’s night a traveler, outside the town of Malbork, leaning from the steep slope without fear of wind or vertigo, looks down in the gathering shadow in a network of lines that enlase, in a network of lines that intersect, on the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon around an empty grave— What story down there awaits its end?—he asks, anxious to hear the story.”

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 258

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is the moment when an anonymous other reader reveals to the Reader that the titles of all the unfinished books the Reader has read all form a coherent sentence when one combines them. But while this reveal seems to suggest that the disconnected stories are more connected than they seem, it also raises new questions, since the connected titles only form the beginning of a story, not a complete thought.

Even though the reader only came across the various story fragments seemingly at random, the fragments nevertheless end up forming something coherent together. This process suggests that something like destiny or even divine intervention is guiding the Reader—like the scribe Abdullah who helped with the Koran, the Reader ends up suggesting the final title in this sequence of titles, “*He asks, anxious to hear the story.*” And so, this passage shows how even in the reader’s disorganized and seemingly random reading journey, it’s possible to find patterns and meaning. This illustrates the power of books to help people better understand the world.

☞ The seventh reader interrupts you: “Do you believe that every story must have a beginning and an end? In ancient times a story could end only in two ways: having passed all the tests, the hero and the heroine married, or else they died. The ultimate meaning to which all stories refer has two faces: the continuity of life, the inevitability of death.”

You stop for a moment to reflect on these words. Then, in a flash, you decide you want to marry Ludmilla.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), You (The Reader), Lotaria, Uzzi Tuzii, Corinna, Professor Galligani

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 259

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is the end of the book’s penultimate chapter. After discussing the various possibilities of reading with seven other readers, the Reader ultimately rejects their academic reading style and decides to seek out a conventional happy ending for himself by marrying Ludmilla, abruptly bringing the novel’s events to a close.

This passage humorously shows how the fear of death motivates the Reader to take action and finally marry Ludmilla. The abruptness of his decision suggests that perhaps the Reader has not actually had a moment of epiphany and is simply frustrated and tired of following his curiosity to look for the truth. Still, in another way, the Reader’s sudden decision to marry Ludmilla may indeed be a sign of character growth, showing how he has learned to put aside his curiosity and doubts for the sake of his own happiness. By marrying Ludmilla, the Reader ultimately rejects Lotaria, the seven readers, Corinna, Uzzi-Tuzii and Galligani, and all the other characters who try to turn reading into an overly technical, complicated task, suggesting that for all her imperfections, Ludmilla’s straightforward method of reading a novel from beginning to end might be best method after all.

Chapter 12 Quotes

☞ And you say, “Just a moment, I’ve almost finished *If on a winter’s night a traveler* by Italo Calvino.”

Related Characters: You (The Reader) (speaker), Ludmilla (The Other Reader), Italo Calvino

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 260

Explanation and Analysis

These are the final lines of the book, which the Reader says when he is lying in bed at night with Ludmilla after their marriage. This short final chapter suggests that the Reader and Ludmilla's ability to read in similar ways together have created a scene of wedded bliss. The reference to Italo Calvino and *If on a winter's night a traveler* call back to the very first chapter of the novel, which also dealt specifically with the Reader's experience of reading Calvino.

This break in the structure of the novel (i.e., having chapters 11 and 12 in a row rather than having a story fragment between them), suggests that perhaps the Reader has finally escaped the cycle of being trapped by his own curiosity. Still, there is a note of the ambiguity in the ending—the Reader is “almost” finished with the book, perhaps suggesting that because the novel ends abruptly, the Reader will still never actually get to finish reading his copy of *If on a winter's night a traveler*. The ending leaves open the question of whether the Reader has truly found satisfaction by limiting himself to Ludmilla's style of reading or whether he will eventually feel the need to go looking for truth and closure again.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

The narrator tells you that you're about to start Italo Calvino's new novel, *If on a winter's night a traveler*. The narrator suggests finding a comfortable reading position and getting rid of any potential distractions. He then asks you to set proper expectations for what you're about to read. He imagines how you must have gone into a bookstore and passed all the **books** you don't want to read in order to make it to the much-smaller section of books you do want to read and finding *If on a winter's night a traveler* there.

The narrator imagines where you'll read the **book**, perhaps at a desk job where you do something useless for the sake of the larger economy. Or he wonders if perhaps you have a practical job like surgeon or bull-dozer driver, in which case it would be too dangerous to read at work. Once it's safe, however, you can begin reading the book and will find that it is fairly short and full of fragments, which the narrator says is fortunate because people today can only think in short fragments of time.

The narrator wonders if you'll recognize the style of the author, Italo Calvino, who has a reputation for changing his style a lot from one **book** to the next. The narrator encourages you not to let this discourage you, assuring you that the book is still very readable and that you might even enjoy some of its unusual qualities.

Right away, the story breaks convention by starting narration in the second person, seeming addressing the reader directly ("you"). Additionally, it's unusual that the book's author, Italo Calvino, appears as a character in his own book. These opening lines ask the audience to reconsider what purpose the typical conventions of a novel serve and what happens if an author upends them.



At this point, the book's audience ("you") still seems to be a character in the story. Once again, the novel questions the purpose of books, noting that reading may not be as important as performing surgery or driving a bulldozer. Still, this passage also begins to reveal how the narrator has a sense of humor and irony. When the narrator says that it's good this book is fragmented to fit with people's short attention spans, he is implicitly suggesting that the pace of modern life (the novel was written in the 1970s) has made people busier and given them less time to read—perhaps the narrator's real problem isn't with books but with the other things taking up people's time.



This passage has a double meaning—while the real-life Calvino did indeed change his style from book to book, this particular novel also contains fragments of fictional books that vary in style—while all ultimately still being the work of the real-life Calvino.



IF ON A WINTER'S NIGHT A TRAVELER

At a **train** station, a man enters a bar, and because the bar is small, everyone turns to look at him. A narrator claims that he is the man, or perhaps the man is called "I," and you can know nothing else about the man or the railway station beyond what the man tells you.

The narrator of this story seems to resemble the narrator of the previous chapter. While this might suggest some continuity, the details about the train station suggest that even though this narrator also calls himself "I," he may not be the same character and may not even be addressing the same "you."



You cannot tell if the **train** station exists in the past, present, or future—perhaps the author (seemingly referring to Calvino) hasn't even decided yet. Speaking in the first-person as the nameless man, the narrator speculates that he must be at the station by accident, due to a delay or missed connection, since he has no one to meet at the station.

Still as the nameless man, the narrator wonders what lies outside the **train** station, if there's a city or if the author (Calvino) choose to leave it blank. The narrator supposes he must be some sort of subordinate, traveling to do a job for someone else more important. He feels that he must be anonymous—someone who disappears into the background. In fact, the narrator feels that the author must have called the nameless man "I" in order to obscure details about him, like his name.

The narrator would like to turn back time, but as the narrative goes on, it associates more details with the "I." The narrator was supposed to meet another man with an identical suitcase, hear the password "Zeno of Elea" from him, then secretly swap suitcases. But now that the narrator's travel plans are ruined, he doesn't know what to do next.

The narrator feels jealous that he doesn't belong in this small city as he watches the locals around him. People in the **train** station speak to each other in familiar terms. The narrator finally decides to join them and begins talking to a beautiful woman who sells suitcases. The woman introduces herself as Dr. Marne's ex-wife. When Dr. Marne himself comes in, he doesn't look at his ex-wife, but he does seem to notice that the narrator is talking to her.

Many stories in the novel question or disrupt the linear flow of time, so it's fitting that this train station seems to exist in a place outside of time. Calvino explores the duality of how people's lives always move forward in time but how people's actual experience with time is more complicated, with memories of the past and hopes for the future driving their lives.



In this novel, Calvino mostly abandons realism, and this passage helps to explain why. Even in the most realistic book, what the audience sees is always limited by what the author writes, and if an author doesn't describe a city beyond a train station, then that city doesn't exist. Furthermore, the narrator questions the convention of a first-person narrator who says "I." While many readers and literary critics consider the first-person an effective technique to explore the inner thoughts of a character, this narrator argues that in fact, first-person narration can actually conceal truths about the narrator, with the narrator's use of "I" allowing him to hide his name.



Zeno of Elea was a famous Greek philosopher who came before Socrates but whose paradoxes are still well known today. Like Calvino's fiction, Zeno's paradoxes question conventional thinking. Zeno proposed that true motion was impossible and so it was impossible for a fast runner to catch up with a tortoise, providing seemingly logical proofs for these claims even though they contradicted people's own experience. Perhaps Calvino invokes Zeno to show how in this novel, the "you" the narrator addresses seems to always get closer to reading the end of a story without ever actually doing so (due to how the story fragments abruptly stop).



With this passage, the story shifts more and more from the general to the specific, which also changes the style from more philosophical to more plot-driven. Whereas previously, the story did not have much conflict or suspense, now there is the question of what will happen with Dr. Marne and his ex-wife together in the same room.



The woman who sells suitcases notices the narrator's suitcase and says she just recently sold one like that to a stranger. She notes that people don't usually buy that specific suitcase. The narrator complains he doesn't want to keep dragging his own suitcase around, so the woman suggests he leave it with her in her suitcase shop.

This passage leaves it ambiguous as to whether the woman talking with the narrator knows the significance of his suitcase or whether she's an innocent observer. This passage provides an early example both of how different people see the world in different ways and also how it isn't always possible to know how other people see the world.



The local police chief, Chief Gorin, comes into the bar and says "Zeno of Elea." The narrator worries that someone has turned him over to the police. He goes over to meet Chief Gorin by the cigarette machine. Chief Gorin tells him that someone named Jan has been killed. He tells the narrator to grab his suitcase and gives him instructions about which **train** to take. While Chief Gorin continues to watch, the narrator gets onto an express train and disappears.

The story ends at a suspenseful moment, with the narrator seemingly fleeing for his life to avoid a fate like Jan's. The express train the narrator gets on suggests that his fate is already determined (since trains move forward along rails), but the fact that the story cuts off so abruptly leaves it ambiguous as to what the narrator's fate is.



CHAPTER 2

The narrator says that you must have noticed a passage in the **book** that's familiar. But as you keep reading, the narrator explains, you'll realize it's just a printing error and that a page has been repeated. You slowly realize that the rest of the book you're holding is just the same 16 pages repeated over and over. You consider throwing the book out the window but decide instead to take it back to the bookseller.

Once again, the novel breaks the flow of time, suggesting that rather than moving forward, the narrator of the previous chapter is doomed to keep repeating the same events over and over. This helps to highlight how even books without printing errors might suggest the possibility of a wider world but are always doomed to feature the same characters repeating the same events again and again. The frustration of the "you" the narrator addresses is more intense because of the printing error. In a broader sense, though, the person the narrator addresses is also upset about realizing that books as a medium have limitations.



The bookseller says he has already gotten several complaints like the one you are making. The bookseller got a letter from the publisher claiming that due to a printing error, some copies of Italo Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* have gotten mixed together with *Outside the town of Malbork* by the Polish novelist Tazio Bazakbhal.

Tazio Bazakbhal is fictional, like all the writers (aside from Calvino) who are credited as authors of these stories within the story. In the real world, Calvino is writing for Bazakbhal, so the presence of multiple authors in the book shows how a single person contains different sides and can take on different personas.



Upon hearing this, you (the Reader) decide you'd rather read the Polish novel than Calvino's. The bookseller says that's fine. In fact, a young lady just asked to do the same thing. But the bookseller says he can't promise the Bazakbhal **books** are correct either. As you go over to find the book, you notice that the young lady, the Other Reader, is very attractive.

The audience's attraction to the Other Reader suggests that as much as reading might seem like a solitary activity, it is ultimately something that can draw people together. In the real world, readers may feel a sense of community with other distant readers just by knowing that others have experienced the same book, and this passage imagines what a tangible variation on that relationship between readers might look like.



You and the Other Reader talk about enjoying Bazakbhal. You talk about novels in general. You laugh at the possibility that maybe the Bazakbhal **book** you're about to buy will actually contain Calvino's book. In case that happens, you and the Other Reader exchange phone numbers. You are happy at the prospect of no longer being a solitary Reader. But as you excitedly begin your new book, you soon realize it's not a continuation of what you were reading before.

Calvino explores how an author's persona can affect the reading experience, even including himself as a character in the novel, and this passage further explores that idea. The "you" the narrator addresses and Other Reader might not have ever discovered the "Bazakbhal" novel if it had had the correct name on it, but because it was incorrectly labeled as Calvino, they discovered an author they like even better than Calvino. One of the reasons why "you" and the Other Reader are more sympathetic (while still flawed) characters in the novel is because they are the characters open to new experiences.



OUTSIDE THE TOWN OF MALBORK

An onion cooks in oil on a stovetop. Unfamiliar characters like Brigd, Hunder, and Jan's widow slowly take shape. The kitchen is located in Kudigwa, and it's full of people.

The beginning of this story is disorienting, throwing out several character names that are familiar to the narrator but unfamiliar to the reader. In many ways, it is the opposite of the previous story, which started with just one narrator and took a long time to reveal any named characters.



The narrator comes into the kitchen. He is leaving home for the first time and about to spend a season on Mr. Kauderer the farmer's estate, while the Mr. Kauderer's son, Ponko, is about to take the narrator's place at Kudigwa. The narrator gets sentimental about the smells of the Kudigwa kitchen because he's about to lose them forever. The narrator asks if you, the Reader, feel that the text is slipping away from you and that perhaps something has been lost in the translation.

Although the narrator of this story is different from the previous narrators, he continues to address his audience as "you," leaving it ambiguous as to whether the novel as a whole contains a multitude of narrators or just one who takes on different forms in each new story. Translation is a recurring theme in the story, and language differences are another reason why different readers might experience the same text in different ways.



As the narrator is packing up his things in preparation to give his room to Ponko, he sees that Ponko is holding a picture of a girl that he is trying to hide. The narrator manages to briefly grab the picture from Ponko and sees that the name "Zwida Ozkart" is written on it. Ponko is angry at the narrator invading his privacy, and the two begin to fight. The narrator feels jealous of how Ponko seems to possess Zwida and also may soon have Brigd, whom the narrator will lose when he leaves.

In the previous numbered chapter, the narrator's audience ("you") has to swap books because of a printing error, and this story echoes that with the swap of the narrator and Ponko. The narrator's seemingly undeclared love for Brigd also reflects the narrator's audience's attraction to Ludmilla, showing how fiction can be a way for people like the narrator's audience to see their own problems reflected in a new form.



Later, the narrator goes into a big room where he overhears Mr. Kauderer the farmer talking about an ongoing feud his family has with the Ozkarts, which just recently led to two deaths in his family. Mr. Kauderer has moved Ponko so he will be safe from the Ozkarts. The narrator's mother worries whether the Ozkarts will accidentally attack Gritzvi (the narrator's name in this story), mistaking him for Ponko. Mr. Kauderer assures her that only Kauderers are in danger, and so the narrator takes a step forward toward Mr. Kauderer.

The story doesn't reveal the narrator's name until the very end (Gritzvi), perhaps to emphasize the point from the first story at the train station about how "I" can be a way of concealing things, like a name. Also like the first story, this one ends with the narrator's life potentially in danger due to forces he doesn't understand. The constant threat of death at the end of these stories suggests that it is a nearly universal human fear the resists easy answers—just as this story doesn't provide closer at the ending.



CHAPTER 3

You (the Reader) use a paperknife to cut into the **book** you're reading. As you look at the book, you realize there was a printing error and there's only text on one side of the pages. You begin to suspect that the book you're holding might not really be *Outside the Town of Malbork* after all, since names like Brigd aren't Polish. You realize instead that the story must be set in the country of Cimmeria.

By now, the novel has settled into a rhythm where the audience knows to expect the novel's embedded stories to end abruptly, but interestingly, each story gets cut off for different reasons in each case. Although there have been real groups of people called Cimmerians, the few details that Calvino gives here about the time and place of Cimmeria make it clear that it is a fictional country.



You want to contact the Other Reader, whose name it turns out is Ludmilla, but when you call, you instead get her sister, Lotaria. Lotaria says Ludmilla is always reading. She asks you several questions about the **book** you're currently reading, which you can't answer since you're still not sure about which book you actually have.

Lotaria is the opposite of Ludmilla in many ways, and her first appearance in the novel establishes this by presenting her as standoffish and suspicious instead of welcoming, like Lotaria. This reflects how Ludmilla is open to new experiences but Lotaria is more set in her ways.



Lotaria invites you to a seminar at a local university, but you don't want to commit to anything. Eventually Lotaria reveals that Ludmilla doesn't actually live with her and Ludmilla just gives Lotaria's number to people she wants to keep at a distance. You are disappointed, until all of a sudden, a new voice comes over the phone line, and it's Ludmilla herself.

This is the first of many times in the story when the narrator's audience doubts the strength of his connection to Ludmilla. His anxieties reflect how difficult it can be to know what another person is thinking and specifically how it can be difficult to know what someone else will think when they read something.



You (the Reader) and Ludmilla confirm that you both have the same Cimmerian novel. The two of you make plans to speak with Professor Uzzi Tuzii, a professor of Cimmerian literature that Ludmilla knows. Later, you go to the university alone but struggle to find either Ludmilla or the professor. Eventually, you run into a mysterious young man named Irnerio who offers to take you to Uzzi Tuzii.

The narrator's audience's journey to finally read the end of a story takes him to many of the different places traditionally associated with books, first a bookstore and now a university. The novel is an exploration not just of what books contain but also the places and culture that spring up around books.



Innerio reveals to you that even though he's a student, he never reads. The trick is simply to look at words on the page so intensely that they disappear. Innerio takes you to a room at the university that seems to be closed for renovation and leaves you there. But as you enter, you realize that a man you thought was a painter is actually Uzzi Tuzii.

Innerio embodies the type of person who likes to appear knowledgeable and likes the culture around books but who doesn't actually like the physical act of reading. Innerio shows once again how readers won't necessarily have the same experience with a book and how it's possible for some people to read a book without understanding its content.



Uzzi Tuzii asks if you (the Reader) really came to learn about Cimmerian literature, implying that perhaps you really came to see Ludmilla (who still hasn't arrived). You agree to hear more about Cimmeria. The professor tells you that Cimmerian is a dead language, and so his whole department is dead. You insist that in spite of this, you're still interested. You begin mentioning how your novel has characters in it with names like Ponko, Zwida Ozkart, and Brigd.

While Innerio is honest about his unusual motivations for looking at books, the narrator's audience seems to be genuinely conflicted about why he reads. Although he claims to be interested in Cimmeria, it's clear that Ludmilla plays a big role in motivating his ongoing reading quest. Still, there really does seem to be a part of the narrator's audience that is naturally fascinated by seeing the end of stories, which harmonizes with his desire for Ludmilla.



Uzzi Tuzii says the **book** you're thinking of must be *Leaning from the steep slope* by the Cimmerian poet Ukko Ahti. But when you start the book, you realize that although some of the proper names are similar, everything else about the book seems very unfamiliar.

By this point, Calvino's audience is familiar with the novel's structure, and the struggle of the book's unnamed "you" to never finish a story becomes humorous as he finds himself in increasingly improbable situations.



LEANING FROM THE STEEP SLOPE

Monday. The narrator, who writes this whole chapter as a series of diary entries, goes for long walks along the shore every morning. The narrator passes by the prison on his usual route and sees a hand sticking out a window. The narrator is impressed, thinking it must have been very difficult for a prisoner to get a hand through the grilles on the windows.

The diary style of this story immediately differentiates it from the previous ones, fulfilling the narrator's promise at the beginning that "you" will experience a wide range of styles. The diary might seem to be a very personal and revealing genre, but this novel has already raised questions about how first-person narrators can conceal information, raising questions about what the narrator isn't revealing (or is perhaps failing to see).



The narrator resumes his walk and comes across Miss Zwida wearing a white straw hat and sitting in a chair at a seaside hotel. The narrator has been seeing her a lot on his walks despite his efforts to avoid her. He hasn't talked to Miss Zwida yet because he's afraid she'll bring up the topic of seashells, and the narrator won't know how to respond because he used to know a lot about seashells but forgot everything he knew.

Zwida Ozkart was a character in the previous story, but aside from the name, there is nothing to suggest that this new Zwida has any direct relation to that previous character. Nevertheless, this Zwida does have some traits in common with many of the other female characters in the story, fascinating the male protagonist because he seemingly has something in common with her (in this case, an interest in seashells), but also remaining at an unreachable distance.



Later that Monday, the narrator talks with Mr. Kauderer the meteorologist who works at a local observatory. The narrator likes how Mr. Kauderer seems reserved but becomes friendly whenever they talk about the weather. Mr. Kauderer mentions he has a trip coming up and asks if he can trust the narrator to record some data while Mr. Kauderer is away. The narrator agrees.

Tuesday. The narrator talks to Miss Zwida for the first time. He makes conversation about a sketch of a sea urchin that she's working on. After the narrator leaves to go check on the observatory, he sees two men there in heavy black coats who ask to see Mr. Kauderer the meteorologist. When the narrator says Mr. Kauderer is away, the men say it's not important and leave.

Wednesday. The narrator goes to the hotel and finds Miss Zwida wearing a black veil. The narrator then sees the two men in black. Later in the day, he ponders while writing in his diary who will ever read what he writes and if they'll even understand his meanings.

Thursday. The narrator learns that Miss Zwida has a permit to visit the prison on specific days. He sees her in the prison yard but says nothing. Later, the two of them talk. The narrator mentions that if he ever learned how to draw, he'd only be interested in inanimate objects. Miss Zwida says she'd like to draw a grapnel (a type of anchor) with 12 meters of rope attached to it. As a young lady, she's embarrassed about buying a grapnel herself, so the narrator offers to get her one.

Thursday evening. The narrator goes to a bar to celebrate his day, which he feels has brought him closer to Miss Zwida. He overhears some men talking about a woman who offers to pay him 100 crowns to be left alone with a prisoner.

Friday. When the narrator tries to buy a grapnel, the fisherman he's talking to gets suspicious and tells him to go see a Chandler. But the Chandler also acts suspicious and refuses to sell to the narrator. The Chandler explains that in the past, a grapnel has been used to help a prisoner escape the local prison.

Mr. Kauderer is yet another character who shares a name with a character from the previous story. In some ways, Mr. Kauderer the meteorologist is similar to Mr. Kauderer the farmer, since both a meteorologist and a farmer need to pay attention to the weather.



The men in black coats from this suggest crime or espionage, recalling the paranoid mood of the first story. The narrator characters often get glimpses of powers bigger than themselves, with the men in black coats suggesting secret police, spies, or other shadowy government agents.



Miss Zwida's black veil could suggest that she is conspiring with the strange men, or it could suggest that the presence of these strange men in town is a cause for mourning. While the narrator questions if anyone will understand what he writes, perhaps the real question is how much the narrator himself understands, including if there are things about the mysterious Miss Zwida he isn't able to perceive.



Miss Zwida's request for a grapnel with 12 meters of rope is very specific—although the narrator takes it at face value, it's clear that there's something strange about her request. Perhaps the narrator doesn't understand Miss Zwida because, as he claims, he's only interested in inanimate objects, and so the complexities of another person like Miss Zwida are too much for him.



The narrator feels good enough about his day to celebrate, ignoring all the ominous signs in the story so far, like the men in black coats and the strangeness of Zwida's request. This passage strongly implies that Zwida is the woman making bribes to see a prisoner, but the naïve narrator doesn't make the connection.



The grapnel combined with the mention in the previous section of a woman bribing prison guards suggests that Zwida is indeed planning to break someone out of prison, and yet it's still unclear whether the narrator realizes this.



Saturday. Mr. Kauderer the meteorologist is back and has sent a note to the narrator, asking him to meet Mr. Kauderer at night at a cemetery. But when the narrator gets to the cemetery, the grave-digger says Mr. Kauderer isn't there. The narrator enters anyway and is surprised when Mr. Kauderer pulls him aside.

The cemetery is yet another reminder of death in the novel. Mr. Kauderer's absence and sudden appearance seem to suggest that he is in a transitional state, perhaps forced into hiding to avoid the men in black coats pursuing him. Metaphorically, this places him in a state between alive and dead.



Mr. Kauderer the meteorologist says the narrator has been reckless, putting the observatory in danger by getting involved in an escape attempt. Mr. Kauderer makes a vague reference to a larger plan more important than any escape attempt. He then warns the narrator that the police will interrogate him the next day about the grapnel. Mr. Kauderer says that the narrator must not mention his name to the police. In addition, the narrator must give up his role working at the observatory.

Mr. Kauderer uses language that evokes ideas of revolution or rebellion, hinting at a theme that will become more prominent in later stories. It is often difficult to figure out the various allegiances of the characters in the stories, including their true allies and enemies. This resonates with the book's broader focus on the difficulties of knowing another person's perspective (including how they'll react to a book).



Sunday. The narrator goes to the observatory. A storm swirls around him, and the narrator almost feels like he can control it. Suddenly, the narrator hears a creak and looks down. He sees a bearded man in ragged clothes. The bearded man begs the narrator not to betray him. He asks the narrator if he'd be willing to give a message to someone he knows who is staying at the local hotel.

This bearded man is presumably an escaped prisoner who is trying to reach Miss Zwida (who is staying at the hotel and likely his accomplice, based on her earlier actions). Despite all the evidence of conspiracies going on around him, the narrator's own understanding of what he sees remains ambiguous, and it's possible that he remains oblivious. And so, yet again, the story cuts off during a moment of suspense.



CHAPTER 4

You have been listening to Uzzi-Tuzii read aloud and feel that it's a very different experience from reading what's on the page. As Uzzi-Tuzii goes on, he seems to become more and more fluent in the book's language but also interrupts himself to explain aspects of it. As you're getting lost in the story, you suddenly happen to notice Ludmilla in the room and wonder how long she's been there.

This passage illustrates how, while books can contain knowledge, getting too bogged down in technicalities can actually hinder the experience of reading, making it impossible to follow a story. Ludmilla represents the opposite viewpoint of Uzzi Tuzii—of valuing stories more than academic details.



At one point, Uzzi-Tuzii pauses for a while, so Ludmilla asks, "And then?" The narrator tells you that at this point in the novel, the author, Ukko Ahti, sank into writer's block and depression and eventually killed himself. What Uzzi-Tuzii has just read is a fragment published posthumously. Uzzi-Tuzii warns you and Ludmilla not to look for the rest of the book, since Cimmerian novels are at the threshold, speaking "the wordless language of the dead." For this reason, they're all unfinished.

Yet again the novel questions the linear flow of time, framing death not as silence but as a "wordless language." Indeed, many authors continue to "say" things long after their deaths as people continue to read them, with some books even taking on different meanings or significance after the author is dead.



As Uzzi-Tuzii and Ludmilla debate their own philosophies about reading, you feel out of your depth. Ludmilla mentions how in spite of everything, she'd like to finish the novel she's in the middle of. Just then, Lotaria appears, saying she has a novel that she recently studied in a feminist seminar that she thinks is exactly the one Ludmilla is looking for.

Although Ludmilla and Lotaria are sisters, their styles of reading differ significantly. While Ludmilla reads frequently and can talk at length about her philosophy of reading, she is not as rigorously analytical as Lotaria—which might be a good thing.



Ludmilla asks if Lotaria has *Leaning from the steep slope*, but it turns out that she actually has a different novel called *Without fear of wind or vertigo*. Uzzi-Tuzii says he has it on good authority that Lotaria's **book** isn't an authentic Cimmerian text but a forgery. Just then, a pale bearded man named Professor Galligani enters and contradicts Uzzi-Tuzii, saying that recent discoveries have proven that text of *Without fear of wind or vertigo* is authentic Cimmerian.

While the professors in this passage argue about the authenticity of a text, in fact *Without fear of wind or vertigo* and the country of Cimmeria are both inventions of Calvino. It is impossible to know whether Uzzi-Tuzii or Galligani is correct, since Calvino never reveals an answer, perhaps suggesting that some searches for the truth are doomed to be futile.



Ludmilla isn't interested in the debate between Uzzi-Tuzii and Galligani—she just wants to continue reading. Lotaria invites Ludmilla and you to her study group. You go to a classroom, where Galligani gives a lecture on some of the historical context for *Without fear of wind or vertigo*, such as how it was translated into German to reach a broader international audience. But as soon as Lotaria begins to read from this new novel, you know it has no connection to any of the previous ones you've read.

Each of the book's embedded story fragments have supposedly been in a different language so far. On the one hand, this is false, since Calvino wrote them all in Italian. On the other hand, there is an element of truth to this false premise, since this book did indeed get translated into languages like Polish and German. In some ways, the fact that Cimmerian is a fake language refutes the idea that translations are less authentic than the original, since even Calvino's original Italian could never faithfully translate a fake language.



WITHOUT FEAR OF WIND OR VERTIGO

A military parade with musicians marches across town at five in the morning. The narrator is dressed as a soldier and carries a pistol. With him is his friend Valerian, who is in civilian clothes but may also have a pistol, and Irina, who walks arm in arm with both the narrator and Valerian. As they walk, they pass a church that has become a place to quarantine cholera patients. An old woman outside the church shakes her fist and says, "Down with the gentry!"

The previous story hinted at a conspiracy to break people out of prison, and this story continues the theme of going against authority by depicting a city in the middle of a revolution. The political turmoil in these stories suggests a real-world struggle for truth that parallels a reader's journey to find truth.



The narrator says that he mentions the old woman because she seems like a premonition of things to come, like strikes (including at the Kauderer munitions factories) and counterrevolutionary armies.

This story is the third to mention the name Kauderer, although none of the three Kauderers seem to have any relation to each other. In fact, this Kauderer may be the opposite of the Kauderer of the previous story—while Kauderer the meteorologist may have been in an anti-government conspiracy, this Kauderer is apparently part of the group that revolutionaries are rebelling against.



Earlier, when the narrator first meets Irina, it's back when a front of the army has collapsed. In preparation for an advancing foe, people from a citizen militia take up defensive positions in the city while noncombatants try to seek refuge by rushing over the Iron Bridge into the city. Despite the confusion, the narrator feels in harmony with everyone else as he crossed the Iron Bridge. Just then, he notices Irina fall, and fearing she might get trampled, the narrator runs over to help her up.

Each of the stories in this novel contains a distant looming threat of danger, whether it's men in black coats, a deadly feud between families, or in this case, an enemy army approaching. These threats build a sense of dread and suspense, perhaps in part embodying the unsettled feeling that a reader feels when a story refuses to provide closure. The narrators generally don't actually experience pain or death within the story fragments, but the threat always looms over them.



Still in the past, Irina says that she is feeling better, although she doesn't thank the narrator for helping her. He introduces himself to her as Alex Zinnober and says he is the equivalent of a lieutenant (although his regiment has abolished official ranks). Irina and the narrator go walking across the chaotic city where the narrator eventually loses sight of her. He decides to go to the Heavy Industry Commission, where his friend Valerian works.

Although this narrator is one of the few named ones in the story, his status as a revolutionary raises the question of whether he is concealing any part of his identity. The lack of army ranks and the references to strikes earlier would seem to identify Alex Zinnober as a communist, although Calvino deliberately avoids most traditional political labels, perhaps in part to reflect the fact that characters in these stories often have uncertain allegiances. This passage hints that the narrator may be a hypocrite, since despite believing in an army without ranks, he also knows exactly what rank he would be in a traditional army



The narrator finds Valerian behind his desk cleaning a gun. They're talking about the revolution when Irina suddenly appears and reveals she has been eavesdropping. She takes the gun Valerian is cleaning and puts it up against her head as if about to shoot herself. The narrator warns her not to joke about such things. Irina says that the revolution itself is a joke if only men can bear arms and not women.

Valerian's cleaning of his gun is a sign that he is preparing for violence. Irina's comments about the lack of gender equality in the revolution relate back to the frame story for this section (where Lotaria is reading the story aloud in a feminist seminar).



A messenger comes by for Valerian, forcing Irina to hide. After the messenger is gone but Irina is still hidden, the narrator asks Valerian if Irina's jokes are really appropriate, but Valerian says Irina never jokes.

Despite his beliefs in equality (serving in an army that has no ranks), the narrator seems to be more hesitant to include women, revealing potential hypocrisy.



The flashback catches up to the present, and now the narrator, Valerian, and Irina are having a threesome in Irina's room. In the middle of sex, the narrator thinks about how he has to keep a secret: he is looking for a spy who has infiltrated the Revolutionary Committee. At one point, the narrator manages to get away and search Valerian's clothes. He finds that Valerian has a death warrant for the narrator in his pocket. The warrant is for the crime of treason, and it's already signed and stamped.

The ending of this story fragment raises several new questions that will never be answered. The death warrant seems to show that the narrator, Valerian, and Irina have different allegiances after all, but this doesn't stop them from having sex. This ending suggests that urges like lust can be stronger than political allegiances, while also suggesting that it's so difficult to know other people that even a good friend might turn into a betrayer.



CHAPTER 5

The story pauses, and the other students in the seminar begin discussing topics like “the laws of a market economy” and “castration.” You and Ludmilla seem to be the only ones interested in continuing the story. You ask Lotaria for the rest of the **book**, but Lotaria says she’s already given you enough material to discuss for a month. She says that the book had to be cut up and shared with other departments, but she believes she captured the best part of it.

Later, you and Ludmilla meet up, having decided that if the two of you really want to find the endings to any of the novels you’ve read recently, you’ll have to go directly to the publishing house. But then Ludmilla disappoints you by suggesting that perhaps you should go alone and report back to her. She has her principles: She believes some people make **books** and others read them, and she always wants to be on the side of the readers.

When you (the Reader) make it to the publishing house, a small man named Mr. Cavedagna assumes you’re there to check about a manuscript you submitted. He then leads you through the publishing house, and you look around. In this time period, **books** are no longer written by individuals but by groups, like seminars, political parties, and research teams. Finally, you tell Mr. Cavedagna that you’re just a reader, not a writer, and he looks pleased.

Mr. Cavedagna confesses that in spite of all the **books** he’s worked on, he doesn’t really feel like what he does counts as real reading. When you (the Reader) try to interrupt to explain the problem with the unfinished books you’ve been reading, Mr. Cavedagna says he already knows all about it.

You and Mr. Cavedagna discuss the **book** fragments you’ve read recently. Apparently, due to a war, a group of people called the Cimbrians have taken over much of Cimmerian literature. You learn that *Without fear of wind or vertigo* was translated by a young man named Ermes Marana, who claimed to know Cimbrian but in fact didn’t know a word. It turns out that Ermes Marana actually translated a French novel called *Looks down in the gathering shadow* by the Belgian author Bertrand Vandervelde.

Both “market economy” and “castration” are meant to sound like jargon that would come up during an academic discussion about literary theory. It is debatable whether they actually have any relation to the previous story, suggesting that the members of the seminar are using big words to reference topics that they don’t understand.



In some ways, Ludmilla’s distinction between readers and book-makers is arbitrary, since nearly all authors are themselves readers. Still, Ludmilla’s commitment to avoid going to the publishing house also demonstrates her principles, which include accepting books as they are rather than getting bogged down in details about external context, as many people at the university do.



The Reader soon understands why Ludmilla stayed behind: the reality of publishing that he sees is disappointing to him, just as Ludmilla expected. Although the novel depicts many lonely characters who struggle to connect with others, this passage presents the opposite problem, where group-thinking and orthodoxy lead to books that are less personal.



In some ways, Mr. Cavedagna resembles Irnerio, who also frequently deals with books but doesn’t actually read them. Mr. Cavedagna takes a practical view that disappoints the Reader, treating the defective books as just another part of the business.



The name Ermes resembles Hermes, the Greek messenger god, revealing how a translator acts like a messenger between writer and reader. This passage also shows how an author has to place a lot of trust in a translator, since there is always the danger that a translator will misrepresent what an author says (with Marana being an extreme example).



Despite Mr. Cavedagna's claims, as you leaf through *Looks down in the gathering shadow*, you don't think it has any relation to any of the previous books you've read. Ermes Marana wrote Mr. Cavedagna a note defending his fraud, saying that the author's name on a **book** doesn't matter—some great works are anonymous, some famous authors have no surviving works, and some famous authors may in fact be the combined work of multiple authors (like Homer).

Calvino himself bears some resemblance to Marana (since in this novel, Calvino falsely "translates" his own words into fragments of work by other authors). On the one hand, there are reasons to be skeptical of Marana's claims about the insignificance of an author's name on the cover, particularly since Calvino, the real author of this book, is literally a character in the book, and since the opening chapter explores all of the expectations a reader might have for a book by the author Calvino.



Mr. Cavedagna tells you not to let *Looks down in the gathering shadow* leave the office, since it's important evidence in a fraud case. As Mr. Cavedagna gets called away for some important publishing matter, you sit down to read this new novel.

Mr. Cavedagna helps to illustrate how for some, books are just a business matter. Rather than exploring or even celebrating Marana's unusual translations, Mr. Cavedagna's only concern is an upcoming lawsuit.



LOOKS DOWN IN THE GATHERING SHADOW

The narrator is trying to get rid of the body of someone named Jojo, but the body is too big to fit into a large plastic sack. Bernadette suggests getting a second sack for the head. But there are no suitable sacks, and they need to move Jojo from the basement soon.

This story begins in the middle of a dramatic moment, although it's noteworthy that it doesn't depict Jojo's death, just the aftermath. Once again, death is a sinister presence that lingers over the story, not something the story addresses outright.



Eventually, the narrator and Bernadette decide to take Jojo with them in their car as if he's still alive. When two cops on bicycles come by, the narrator and Bernadette pretend that Jojo is very drunk. The dead Jojo convincingly plays along, unlike the live Jojo, who would have been finicky. The narrator and Bernadette are the ones who murdered Jojo.

Several characters in the novel seem to be on linear tracks determined by destiny. Jojo is a darkly humorous extreme example of this, since he is dead and his body has no choice but to go wherever the narrator and Bernadette drag him.



The narrator has been looking for a new life lately because he feels that his past weighs him down too much. An important step in that process will be finding a place to burn Jojo. But with everything on his mind, the narrator forgot to refill the car's tank, and it runs out of gas. The narrator and Bernadette refill the tank, using the gas they'd planned on using to burn Jojo.

Jojo's heavy body is a physical representation of the mental burden of the narrator's past and the bad things he has done. In this passage, the narrator faces the choice between being able to get rid of his past (by burning Jojo's body) or being able to continue moving forward (by using the gas to fill up the car instead). Like many characters in the novel, the narrator has no choice but to move forward.



The narrator thinks back to how he got in this situation in the first place. He and Bernadette coordinated as soon as they heard Jojo was in Paris, and they managed to carry out the murder without Jojo even learning the narrator's identity. The narrator tells more stories about his past, going back further, saying that he wants you to feel like you are as saturated with his past as he is. The narrator has had many names on his passports, but most people know him by the name Ruedi the Swiss.

Bernadette herself never had any role in the narrator's pasts and knew nothing about his history with Jojo before the murder, including how the narrator believes Jojo used to cheat him out of money. Now, in the present, Bernadette gets out of the passenger seat of the car and climbs over the gearshift to start grinding on the narrator's lap, saying that when the narrator burst into the room to kill Jojo, he interrupted Bernadette in the middle of an orgasm. As she finishes, Jojo's body falls on top of them from the back seat.

The narrator tries to explain to Bernadette that he killed Jojo for reasons from the past totally unrelated to her. The two of them get out of the car and take Jojo into an elevator. They want to drop his body off the roof to make it look like a suicide or perhaps as if Jojo made a mistake while attempting to commit a robbery. They complete the deed, leaving Jojo as a small, distant stain in the courtyard, then decide that they still need to dispose of their plastic sack, which could be evidence.

As Bernadette and the narrator get off the elevator on the ground floor, three men stop them and ask to see what's inside the plastic sack. The narrator thinks the men look like relatives of Bernadette's. The narrator shows them the sack, believing it will be empty, but inside, they find a leather shoe that looks like the narrator's.

CHAPTER 6

You want to continue reading, but this is where the photocopied pages end. You find Mr. Cavedagna and ask to see the rest of *Looks down in the gathering shadow*, but he isn't sure where it is. He agrees, though, to send you the rest of his Ernes Marana files from the archives. Marana, writing from a remote village in South America, has sent Cavedagna several letters about various publishing matters. In one, he offers Cavedagna the option of publishing a new, highly anticipated novel called *In a network of lines that enlase* by the Irish writer Silas Flannery.

The narrator's comments about getting bogged down with the past mirror the comments of the narrator in the first story, who noted that names and other personal details unavoidably get attached to the narrator's "I" as a story goes on. And so just as the narrator is bogged down with guilty memories from his past, the audience also begins to attach more details to the narrator, like the name Ruedi the Swiss.



Bernadette in some ways resembles a reader, encountering the narrator near the beginning of this story and only slowly learning about his story—and only the parts that the narrator chooses to reveal. This passage humorously illustrates how sex can be a distraction from death, with Jojo's body in the back seat standing in for the death that seems to be chasing the narrator and Bernadette if they get caught.



The narrator tries to compensate for his own guilt by transferring it to Jojo, making it look as if Jojo is responsible for his own death and that perhaps he even died in the middle of committing a crime. Even after disposing of Jojo, however, he remains a stain the narrator can see in the distance, suggesting that the narrator himself has been "stained" by his past and can't escape it.



Several of the stories in this novel end with the narrator being betrayed, often by a woman he thought he could trust. This story leaves it ambiguous about whether Bernadette betrayed the narrator or if he's just paranoid, perhaps reflecting the narrator's audience's own anxieties that Ludmilla isn't the person he expects her to be.



Calvino took inspiration from the writers of South America, most notably Jorge Borges, whose surreal short stories resemble the story fragments that this novel contains. The reference to South America is a tribute to these writers as well as a reference to how Calvino is himself "translating" their work, not just by literally translating it from Spanish to Italian but also by mixing his inspirations together and applying his own style to them.



More letters from Ermes Marana come from around the world and describe his work on translating Silas Flannery's *In a network of lines that enlace*. These letters seem to break the flow of time, with some letters referring to events that happened after they were supposedly written. Marana blames delays in his translation on the fact that the author Flannery is himself having a spiritual crisis that has held up his writing.

Ermes Marana's letters reveal that he gets caught up in webs of conspiracies around the world, at one point moving to Arabia to make translations for a fiction-loving Sultana (wife of a sultan). The Sultan is afraid the Sultana will launch a conspiracy against him whenever she finishes reading, and so, inspired by *1001 Arabian Nights*, Marana gets the idea to translate novels but always stop at the most suspenseful moment in order to keep the Sultana occupied.

You continue to read Ermes Marana's letters and see more mysterious female figures like the Sultana, often with some connection to Silas Flannery. Also like the Sultana, most of these women are readers, making you think of Ludmilla.

Ermes Marana has founded an organization that breaks into two sects, the "enlightened" followers of the Archangel of Light and the "nihilistic" followers of the Archon of Shadow. The two factions fight, and each wants to be the first to get its hands on Silas Flannery's next novel, which each believes will reveal important ideas to the world. You get so involved in this conflict that you want to find Marana yourself to ask which faction has the right idea. You also want to read *In a network of lines that enlace*, which is a translation of either a real or faked Flannery novel that Marana sent to Mr. Cavedagna.

You go to meet Ludmilla at a café. While you're waiting for her to arrive, you start reading *In a network of lines that enlace*.

Even the "real world" that the narrator's audience lives in contains elements of fantasy, from the made-up country of Cimmeria to Marana's letters that seem to break the flow of time. The novel thus emphasizes that it is difficult to figure out the truth not just in fiction, but also in the real world in which the novel's readers exist.



1001 Arabian Nights is a massive collection of Middle Eastern folktales linked by a frame story. In the frame story, the ruler of the land has condemned the woman Scheherazade to death, but she manages to stay alive by entertaining him with stories, leaving the ruler in too much suspense to kill her. *Arabian Nights* is a clear inspiration for *If on a winter's night a traveler*, which also features a frame story about a man in constant suspense by the stories he hears.



Both the Sultana and Ludmilla resemble Scheherazade from *Arabian Nights* with their mastery of stories, with the key difference being that they read them while Scheherazade tells them. This chapter explores how reading, writing, and translation are all connected activities.



The factions that Marana founds resemble the shadowy organizations that seem to be lurking in the backgrounds of many of the frame story's embedded narratives. The narrator gets just as involved in these real-world conflicts (which might not be "real," given Marana's reputation as a counterfeiter), showing once again how the truth can be nebulous. The "lines that enlace" in the title of the upcoming story could refer to the novel's many conspiracies, which all offer different versions of the truth.



Once again, Ludmilla is absent, and so the Reader is forced to go ahead without her, reflecting how tenuous connections between people can be.



IN A NETWORK OF LINES THAT ENLACE

The narrator compares the feeling of starting a new **book** to the feeling of hearing the first ring of a telephone. The narrator often feels anxiety about telephones, hearing them in other houses and assuming that it's his own telephone.

Every morning before going to class, the narrator jogs. Sometimes, as he passes by houses, he can hear telephones inside them, as if the telephones are chasing him. Other times, everything is silent. One day, he becomes obsessed with a house where the telephone keeps ringing, but no one answers. He circles the house a few times before eventually leaving to continue his run.

The narrator runs until there are no more houses. But he can't forget the constantly ringing telephone, so eventually he turns around to go back to that house with the telephone. He answers the phone and says that no one is home. The voice on the other end doesn't seem to listen to the narrator and instead starts giving him an address. The voice says that someone named Marjorie is tied up and will be waking soon. If the narrator doesn't come to see Marjorie within half an hour, the house she's in will be burned to the ground.

The narrator feels he should call the police or the fire department. But he doesn't know how to explain to them why he picked up the telephone in the first place, so eventually, he just runs out. He wishes the best for Marjorie.

The narrator tries to think of any Marjorie he knows and eventually remembers Marjorie Stubbs from when she attended a class he was teaching. The narrator noticed her because she was attractive, but he feels he embarrassed himself when he invited her back to his house to lend her some **books**—she refused, misunderstanding his intentions.

The narrator keeps running, seeing some girls on campus who are headed to his class. He asks one of them about Marjorie, and the student says she hasn't seen Marjorie in two days. The narrator immediately sprints to the address he heard on the phone. There is Marjorie Stubbs tied to a sofa and gagged. The narrator releases her, but she just calls him a "bastard."

This story begins with yet another metaphor for the experience of reading. The "network of lines that enlace" in the title could refer to the literal telephone lines that connect people, or it could also refer more metaphorically to how reading builds connections between people.



The unanswered telephone symbolizes how even with the technology to connect people instantly, it can still be difficult to communicate. The narrator's obsession with the unanswered phone perhaps reflects a fear of this lapse in communication—mirroring the Reader's fear that Ludmilla has abandoned him at the café.



The narrator tries to communicate, but his efforts only confuse him further. The "network of lines that enlace" now stand for the conspiracy that the narrator has somehow gotten involved in, as well as perhaps representing the ropes used to tie up Marjorie. The narrator came looking for connection but instead found restrictions, as he himself gets "tied up" in a complicated conspiracy.



When the narrator is in danger, he thinks of social institutions like the police or fire departments and realizes they can do nothing to help him, showing the limits of what government can do.



The relationship between the narrator and Marjorie is yet another relationship that parallels the relationship between the Reader and Ludmilla. Notably, just as the narrator struggles to communicate on the telephone, he also struggles to communicate in person with Marjorie.



And so, the narrator's story is an exaggerated representation of anxiety. The narrator said one wrong thing to Marjorie in the past, and now it has come back to haunt him, with her kidnapped and blaming him for it. Even after untying Marjorie, the narrator remains entangled in the conspiracy, reflecting the difficulty of communicating.



CHAPTER 7

Ludmilla is late for her meeting with you (the Reader) at the café. Eventually, you are so preoccupied waiting for her that you can no longer read. Just then a server at the café calls you and says you have a phone call. It's Ludmilla on the line. She invites you to her house, although she says she isn't there yet.

You go to Ludmilla's house and can tell she lives alone, although you try not to snoop too much. The narrator pauses the story to give more details about you, the Reader. Until this point, the narrator has revealed few details about the Reader, other than the fact that the Reader is male, so that any potential reader can identify with the Reader. It's a deliberate choice that "you," the Reader, have no name, because by giving Ludmilla a name and referring to her in the third person, she now has a more concrete form.

The narrator temporarily changes perspectives, calling Ludmilla "you" and only referring to you in the third person, as "The Reader." Ludmilla lives in a house where the prominent placement of **books** shows that she keeps the outside world at a distance. Her kitchen suggests that she cooks somewhat regularly and has modest tastes.

The narrator describes in the third person how the Reader looks around Ludmilla's house. While Ludmilla's possessions are important to her, her house nevertheless hides many aspects of her personality. Her books seem to show that she isn't the type of Reader who re-reads things.

Whereas the previous chapter involved a narrator who seemed to be haunted by an ever-present telephone ring, this chapter begins with the opposite, where the Reader is impatiently awaiting a call that seems like it might never come. At both extremes, the difficulty of communication can cause anxiety.



While it seemed the chapters of the frame story had begun to settle into a rhythm, here the narrator abruptly and deliberately disrupts the flow of the narrative. The narrator once again draws attention to the conventions of a novel in a way that breaks the audience's immersion, indicating a distinction between "the Reader" who is actively reading the novel and "the Reader" about whom that audience reads. (Note that while the narrator suggests that leaving "the Reader" or "you" nameless means that any potential reader may identify with the Reader, they fail to account for the book's non-male readers.) The novel itself seems to be struggling to communicate, mirroring the Reader's own anxieties about communication.



The story has strongly identified with the Reader so far, but this passage encourages the audience to look beyond the Reader and see how his perspective might be limited. For example, here, the Reader assumes that Ludmilla uses books to keep the outside world at a distance—but he might just be projecting the way that he himself uses books.



Ludmilla's decision not to re-read books makes her like the other characters in the novel who are fated to only move forward in time. Unlike many of those characters, however, she seems to move forward without holding on to the regrets of the past—or at least that's what the Reader thinks.



The narrator changes back to his original perspective so that when he says “you,” he means the Reader, not Ludmilla. You are reassured that Ludmilla has so many books because reading is solitary and that suggests that she doesn’t have any men in her life.

You hear a key turn and are surprised to see it’s not Ludmilla but a man entering. You tell him Ludmilla isn’t around. It turns out to be Irnerio, who says he knows Ludmilla is gone but that he’s come to pick up one of her books. He doesn’t want to read it but instead to use it as material for an art project he’s working on. You are dismayed at how easily Irnerio just takes a book from Ludmilla’s shelf, which seemed like a wall meant to keep out invaders.

You wonder about the relationship between Irnerio (who has said he never reads) and Ludmilla (the avid reader). Irnerio wants to take *In the network of lines that enlace* for his art project, but you don’t want to give up your own book, so you instead hand Irnerio a very similar looking one. In fact, you realize the new book is almost identical to *In a network of lines that enlace*—and it’s also written by Silas Flannery. Irnerio explains that the book you’ve handed him isn’t Ludmilla’s.

Irnerio takes you into a little storage room where there is a typewriter on a table. You see that in the typewriter is a sheet that says, “Translation by Ermes Marana.” You think back to how all the women you read about in the letters of Marana seemed to remind you of Ludmilla. You ask if Marana lives in this house, but Irnerio says it was Marana’s time to leave. When he was around, Ludmilla was unhappy and didn’t read. Marana has a way to make even true things seem false.

Just then, Ludmilla enters. She’s happy to see you with Irnerio. Sometime later, while you’re all having tea, Irnerio disappears. Ludmilla tells you it’s common for him to leave without saying anything. When you ask questions to Ludmilla about her visitors, she asks if you’re jealous. You say you have no right to be jealous, so she asks if you could imagine a future scenario where you would have a right to be jealous.

The Reader feels reassured in this passage, and the structure of the novel itself mimics this feeling of reassurance by returning to the familiar pattern of “you” once again referring to the Reader—the Reader who is physically reading Calvino’s book, and the Reader (“you”) about whom the audience of Calvino’s book is reading. This reinforces the book’s broader point that readers gravitate toward interpretations of books that align with their own understandings of truth—it is comforting, in other words, to relate to and sympathize with a book’s protagonist.



This section casts doubt on the Reader’s observations from the previous passages, suggesting both the limits of his perception as well as the limits of what a person’s possessions can say about them. While the narrator has a reverent attitude toward Ludmilla’s books, Irnerio just walks in and takes one to use for his art project, suggesting that the narrator’s ideas about the sanctity of books may not be as widespread as he thinks.



Irnerio’s willingness to take a similar-looking book with different content highlights how superficial his relationship with books is. The Reader finds that he and Ludmilla are the only ones who truly appreciate the contents of books on their own terms (although his perspective is of course biased by his own limited perception and his attraction toward Ludmilla).



This strange passage seems to confirm the Reader’s fear earlier that Marana had some relationship with Ludmilla (who did not herself appear in any of Marana’s letters but who reminded the Reader of many of the women Marana met). Marana, who deliberately spreads falsehoods and counterfeits, seems to have disturbed Ludmilla’s happy reading by making her question the authenticity of what was in her books.



After a long absence, when it seemed possible that Ludmilla might never come back, her return to the story suggests that her connection with the narrator may not be all in his head after all. In fact, the Reader even tries to downplay the idea of any connection between himself and Ludmilla. But Ludmilla encourages the Reader, once again showing how the Reader’s limited perception has caused him to misread the situation.



The narrator now uses “you” in the plural to address both the Reader (you) and the Other Reader (Ludmilla), since the Reader and Other Reader are in bed together, forming a “two-headed person.” But the narrator notes that actually, from a grammatical standpoint, perhaps it makes more sense to refer to each reader as a singular “you” rather than both as a plural “you.” The Reader and the Other Reader “read” each other’s bodies in bed.

This passage evokes a famous quote from Shakespeare about sex creating a “beast with two backs.” In this passage, the narrator compares the physical intimacy of sex to two different readers reaching the same understanding about a book. Although English does not distinguish between singular and plural in the second person (both are “you”), it is an important distinction in other languages, which is why the narrator comments on the proper grammar to use for the Reader and the Other Reader together.



Now the narrator calls the Reader “you” again. You tell Ludmilla about the book you were just reading. She wants to read it immediately, so you get out of bed to find the book. But as you search, you can’t find it—Irrerio took it for his art show after all. You instead come back with Ludmilla’s other copy of the book. She says she received it from Silas Flannery himself.

This passage reaffirms how the connection between Ludmilla and the Reader is both sexual and based on a shared understanding of reading. But after that moment of mutual understanding, the Reader now realizes he has grabbed the wrong book, suggesting that his troubles with communication will persist even after his sex with Ludmilla.



But as it turns out, the book you found is not the one you expected after all. Ludmilla explains that Hermes Marana always liked to play tricks on Ludmilla and make things false, partly because he was always afraid of a rival coming between him and Ludmilla: her passion for reading. As you look closer at the book in your hands, you realize that it’s not actually *In a network of lines that enlase* but in fact a book called *In a network of lines that intersect*.

Marana and the falsehoods that he spread were part of what was keeping the Reader and Ludmilla apart. Although the Reader and Ludmilla thought that Marana’s absence would remove this obstacle, his presence continues to haunt them both. The Reader and Ludmilla’s relationship is based on mutual understanding, but the counterfeit translator Marana causes both of them to doubt what is or isn’t true.



IN A NETWORK OF LINES THAT INTERSECT

The narrator feels that mirrors help him think, so he collects kaleidoscopes to help him make decisions. The narrator has been able to transform his collecting into a surprisingly profitable business. He is involved in many complicated business dealings and is afraid that his rivals will try to kidnap him.

The kaleidoscope is an apt metaphor for this novel as a whole, which contains several different fragments that all resemble each other. The narrator’s desire to consult kaleidoscopes to help with making decisions suggests that he likes to consider things in a disorderly manner from every angle.



To avoid being kidnapped, the narrator has five decoy Mercedes vehicles that resemble his own and sometimes exit the armored gate of his villa. He also fears that people like his wife, Elfrida, will find out about his extramarital relationship with a divorced woman named Lorna. Eventually, the narrator feels he hasn’t done enough to protect himself and begins staging false kidnappings to throw people off.

The narrator’s efforts to protect himself end up causing him more problems than they solve, particularly when he tries to avoid getting kidnapped by actually kidnapping himself first. This passage satirizes the paranoid attitudes that some governments use to justify oppression in order to “protect” their citizens.



The narrator finds a way to exploit his fake kidnappings by forming insurance companies. But one day, during a false kidnapping, the narrator gets unexpectedly taken back to his house and locked in a mirror room. He wonders if he's somehow kidnapped himself. In the center of the mirror room, Lorna lies tied up. The narrator frees Lorna, but she gets angry and accuses him of tying her up.

Ultimately, the narrator's own efforts to protect himself lead to him trapping himself instead. Fittingly, in a network of lines that enlace and in a network of lines that intersect end up having some strong similarities beyond their similar titles: both end with the narrator seeing a woman he knows tied up and the woman blaming him for it.



Elfrida comes into the mirror room and says she kidnapped the narrator for his own protection. But when Elfrida asks how to get out of the mirror room, the narrator doesn't know. He loses track of what's him and what's just a reflection.

The narrator's inability to tell himself apart from a reflection is a representation of how throughout the story he was unable to tell the difference between real danger and paranoia.



CHAPTER 8

The narrator is Silas Flannery, who is writing in his diary. Every day before going to work at his typewriter, he likes to use a spyglass to look out from his chalet at a woman who is reading in a deck chair. Sometimes, when he's writing, he imagines that the woman is reading the very sentence that he is in the middle of writing, watching him write just as he watches her read.

Once again, a story revolves around a man who is fascinated by a woman who is always at a distance to him. This time, however, the audience expects another chapter about the Reader and instead gets a chapter of diary entries by Silas Flannery. As a writer, Flannery provides a different perspective from most of the characters the novel has introduced so far, many of whom were readers, not writers.



The narrator sometimes thinks of his books as already existing, and so his writing is just an attempt to translate them into a readable form. He has an idea for a story about two writers, one who's productive and one who's tormented. At first the productive writer dismisses the tormented writer's work as bad, but as he watches the tormented writer struggle, he begins to feel that in fact, it is his own work that's superficial.

While Marana is in some ways a surrogate for Calvino (the real author, not the character in this novel), Flannery is another potential surrogate. Flannery's books seem to have a very different reputation from Calvino's (Calvino's work is literary, whereas Flannery's is pulpy), but this chapter could suggest some truths in the writing process that hold true for both pulp and literary fiction.



In the narrator's imagined story, there is a young woman reading a book in the sun. Perhaps the young woman receives a manuscript each from the productive writer and the tormented writer, only to realize that the two manuscripts are identical. Or perhaps she mixes the manuscripts up and returns each to the wrong writer, offending them. The narrator imagines many other possible things that could happen to mess up the manuscripts.

This passage questions the popular idea that making art involves suffering. Flannery seems to want to believe that suffering is not helpful and that it would be better to be able to work like the more productive writer. This desire is no doubt motivated by the fact that Flannery himself is experiencing writer's block and doesn't want to have to suffer from it any more.



In the real world, at his desk, the narrator has a poster of Snoopy typing “It was a dark and stormy night...” He is fascinated by how the “It” suggests an action that’s totally impersonal. The narrator feels he’ll have to take down his Snoopy poster because with it up, he gets so interested in beginnings and the potential they represent that he can never finish any of his works.

The narrator begins copying lines from [Crime and Punishment](#) to try to see what makes a good beginning. He gets a visit from a man claiming to be his translator, warning him that unauthorized translations of his books have been popping up recently—but in fact these books aren’t anything the narrator himself has ever written. The narrator acts insulted by the fakes, but in fact a part of him is intrigued and perhaps even flattered. He learns that his translator’s name is Ermes Marana.

Ermes Marana explains to the narrator that he currently lives in Japan. He gets off track talking about a theory of how authors are all fictional characters, invented by authors to tell their stories. The narrator keeps thinking of his conversation with Marana even days later and how it applies to his own writing methods. He thinks about how the Koran was a collaboration between Mohammad and a scribe. Mohammad allowed the scribe to write the final lines of the Koran, which cause the scribe to lose his faith in Mohammad, but in fact, it was always Allah’s plan to include the scribe’s ending.

The narrator tries not to think of people like publishers and literary agents who are awaiting his novel. He goes for a walk on a mountain trail and meets some boys trying to spot UFOs. They say they’ve heard of a writer nearby in the middle of a crisis and believe aliens are sending him ideas to his brain that he isn’t even aware of. The narrator wonders if it really is possible that his writing is being determined by extraterrestrials.

Snoopy is a dog from the popular comic strip Peanuts. “It was a dark and stormy night...” is supposedly a bad and clichéd beginning to a novel, and yet Flannery finds something interesting about it. This suggests how Flannery also finds interest in pulp books in general (as well as mirroring how the real author Calvino finds interest in the fake pulp author Flannery).



Like many characters in the story, Flannery worries that his attempts to communicate are getting garbled and misunderstood. Once again, Marana creates doubt wherever he goes, making Flannery fear that, even if he finds the right words to write, Marana might somehow change them in the translation process, distorting his message.



The Koran is the holy book of Islam, and Mohammad is the prophet who founded Islam. The narrator compares the process of Mohammad writing the Koran with a scribe to his own writing process. Just as tradition holds that Allah revealed the words of the Koran verbatim to Mohammad and his scribe, Flannery and Marana have their own unusual relationship. Supposedly, Flannery dictates the precise words that Marana translates, but in fact, Marana seems to add some chaos to the translation, just as Mohammad’s scribe potentially adds something to the Koran with his final lines.



This passage explores a modern version of the writing of the Koran, suggesting how in the past people believed that Allah was dictating the words to a writer but now people believe in UFOs sending messages to Flannery’s brain. While the addition of aliens might seem outlandish, this chapter sticks so closely to Flannery’s perspective that it’s difficult to tell what Flannery might not be perceiving, including whether or not he is actually receiving alien messages.



Still, the narrator has writer's block. A girl named Lotaria is writing a thesis on one of his novels and comes to visit him. The narrator is disappointed that Lotaria seems to have already made up what she wanted to find in his books and read them solely to find the thing she's looking for—he prefers for people to find things even he himself didn't know were in there. Lotaria says that is a passive way of reading, like what her sister Ludmilla does—but Lotaria believes that there is a better way to read, even for less interesting authors like Silas Flannery, the narrator.

That evening, the narrator begins to feel that he sees shadowy strangers slipping out of view. He begins to feel that people are messing with his possessions, and when he looks at his manuscripts, he doesn't remember writing them.

The narrator lends some books to Lotaria, but she says she can't read them because she doesn't have her computer, which she uses to analyze books and "read" them in five minutes. She finds the most commonly used words in a book, removing common ones like articles, and uses the remaining words to determine what the book is like. She shows the narrator several such word lists.

The narrator is disturbed to know how Lotaria must be reading his books, and he can't help thinking of it as he tries to write. Later, the narrator is surprised to meet Ludmilla. Ludmilla gives some strong opinions about the best way to read, and the narrator initially thinks that she's attacking Lotaria, but in fact, she's criticizing Hermes Marana. The narrator asks if he's what Ludmilla expected, and she says yes. She wishes she could watch him in the act of writing.

Ludmilla talks about how she believes the physical act of writing helps get at the truth of literature. The narrator agrees and approaches Ludmilla, attempting to hold her, but she wriggles away and tells him he's gotten the wrong idea. She says that although she *could* have sex with him, it wouldn't bring either of them any closer to the truth of Silas Flannery, as he exists in her mind as the author of his novels.

Once again, Lotaria represents a certain school of academic reading. Her determination to make books fit with her preconceived ideas shows close-mindedness and suggests the limits of taking too academic of an approach to reading. By contrast, Flannery, despite his low critical reputation, is more open to trying to be surprised by the things he reads.



This passage seems to offer evidence that Flannery is indeed receiving communications from UFOs—but it's also possible that he's just paranoid, like the man who collects kaleidoscopes and lives in constant fear of kidnapping from In a network of lines that intersect (supposedly a novel by Flannery, or possibly Marana's counterfeit translation).



Lotaria's method of "reading" is so scientific and abstract that it misses the point. Whereas Ludmilla appreciates the experience of reading, Lotaria wants to reduce reading to a dry exchange of information, like a message that can be decoded.



If Lotaria is Flannery's idea of a nightmare reader, then it makes sense that Ludmilla, who is opposite of her sister, would be Flannery's ideal reader. Ludmilla's criticisms of Marana help Flannery put aside his fears that anything he writes will be mistranslated and misunderstood.



Although Ludmilla has an understanding with Flannery, as she does with the Reader, Ludmilla stated earlier that she sees herself as firmly on the side of readers, not writers. Writers observe the world, and Flannery seems to be better at observing women at a distance through his spyglass than he is as communicating with them in person.



After Ludmilla leaves, the narrator goes to his spyglass to see the woman in the deck chair, but she's not there. Later, during another conversation, the narrator tells Ludmilla about the woman he watches. Ludmilla asks whether the woman looks upset or calm. She concludes that, since the woman always looks calm, she must be reading upsetting books.

Several parts of the novel emphasize how the Reader is similar to the narrators in the stories he reads. But as Ludmilla points out here, reading can also be a way of having experiences different from one's own, with the woman on the deck chair seemingly feeling calmed by upsetting books. Ludmilla's words make sense since she is the character who always looks for new experiences when reading.



Later, the narrator thinks about apocrypha (works that are hidden or falsely attributed) and how he'd like to collaborate with Hermes Marana to make some apocrypha, but he doesn't know where to find him. Ludmilla will tell the narrator nothing about Marana's whereabouts—in fact, she's trying to avoid him.

Flannery tries to put aside his fears about Marana by collaborating with him instead of avoiding him. His willingness to embrace ambiguity and falsehood means that he isn't as similar to Ludmilla as he thought after all, since Ludmilla likes to believe that what she reads is true.



The next time that the narrator sees the UFO searchers, he tells them he knows where they can find their extraterrestrial **book**. He takes them to his spyglass to show them the woman reading in the deck chair. She isn't there, so instead, the narrator shows them a man reading a book in city clothes who happens to be sitting on a rocky ledge.

After deciding he wants to work with Marana, Flannery begins to embrace his mystical side. He does not know if he's actually getting messages from extraterrestrials, but he takes the disappearance of the woman on the deck chair and the appearance of the man in city clothes as a sign. This passage explores how both reading and writing involve looking for patterns.



Later, a Reader visits the narrator and tells him that he has two copies of one of the narrator's **books** that look similar on the outside but contain very different novels on the inside. One is about a ringing telephone and the other is about a rich kaleidoscope collector. The Reader is concerned, but the narrator assures him the book is just a fake, so he should forget about it.

Once again, a narrator refers to the Reader in the third-person, rather than in the second-person as "you." Like Ludmilla, the Reader is concerned about authenticity. Flannery himself had these concerns at the beginning of the chapter, but after considering Marana, he has become more comfortable with ambiguity and falsehoods.



The Reader is still disappointed about not being able to finish what he was reading, so the narrator tells him that the one fake **book** he was reading was actually a Japanese novel by Takakumi Ikoka called *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*. As the narrator gives the book to the reader, he seals it in order to conceal the fact that actually it has nothing to do with the novel the reader was describing.

Flannery uses his conversation with the Reader to test out what it would be like to be Marana. By falsely presenting a Japanese novel as the continuation of one of his own books, Flannery makes up his own counterfeit translation. In the real world, Japanese writers were an influence on Calvino, in particular Jun'ichirō Tanizaki.



The Reader tells the narrator that he knows who's behind all the fakes: Ermes Marana. The narrator tells the Reader to do something about it himself, and the Reader notes that when he goes on a business trip to South America, he will try to find Marana. The narrator doesn't mention that Marana is currently in Japan, at least as far as he knows.

The main difference between the Reader and Ludmilla is that, while each wants the truth, Ludmilla tries to find it by avoiding Marana while the Reader wants to find Marana in person, believing that the only way to get to the truth is to confront the counterfeiter rather than avoiding him.



The narrator describes his idea for a novel made up of just the beginnings of novels, since he feels he always runs out of ideas at a certain point in the middle. The protagonist could be a Reader who keeps getting interrupted, and he imagines other characters like an Other Reader and a fake translator. The narrator decides to send the Reader away, reading a copy of *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*, so that the narrator can have some time alone with the Other Reader. Perhaps to make the Reader less lonely, the narrator will give the Other Reader a sister.

Flannery's idea for a novel is nearly identical to Calvino's own. This recalls Flannery's earlier musings about how a tormented author and a productive author might somehow arrive at the same manuscript. It also recalls a famous short story by Jorge Borges ("Pierre Menard, Author of the Quixote") that similarly explored the idea of how two very different authors could arrive at the same book. In fact, in this passage Flannery seems to have a godlike power to manipulate his own world and send the Reader away, further blurring the line between character and author.



ON THE CARPET OF LEAVES ILLUMINATED BY THE MOON

Yellow ginkgo leaves fall from the trees as the narrator and Mr. Okeda walk along a path. The narrator talks about the beauty of the leaves, but Mr. Okeda is more reserved and hesitant to commit to statements. The narrator has been living with the Okedas and has just started noticing the grace of their youngest daughter, Makiko.

Once again, a story fragment revolves around a male narrator who notices women at a distance. The premise of a young man living with another family also recalls Outside the town of Malbork. This narrator demonstrates enthusiasm for beauty, whether it's the leaves or Makiko, and his tendency to mix up different types of beauty will cause problems for him in this story.



One day, the narrator is strolling along the river with Mr. Okeda, Makiko, and Madame Miyagi (Makiko's mother). The narrator has noticed that Madame Miyagi and Mr. Okeda seem to have a tense relationship. At one point, the narrator stoops down to grab a water lily. Makiko and Madame Miyagi bend down next to him, and the narrator feels the left nipple of Makiko and the right nipple of Miyagi. The narrator tries to move to pretend to accidentally squeeze Makiko, but instead his hand finds the lap of Miyagi, who seems to welcome him.

This passage depicts the narrator as literally caught between Madame Miyagi and Makiko. Makiko seems to represent the "correct" choice for the narrator, because she is young, graceful, and innocent. But when the narrator reaches for her, he instead finds Madame Miyagi (perhaps as a punishment for his attempts to be sneaky). The contrast between Makiko and Miyagi seems to parallel the contrast between Ludmilla and Lotaria, with Ludmilla also representing a more innocent way of looking at the world and Lotaria representing jaded experience.



Over the next few days, the narrator ends up spending more time alone with Makiko and Madame Miyagi, as Mr. Okeda does research in the library that the narrator was originally supposed to do, while the narrator rearranges file cards for him. The narrator gets bored of the work and often seeks out Makiko or Madame Miyagi.

This passage makes it clear that either Mr. Okeda has a low opinion of the narrator or Mr. Okeda is the type of person who doesn't easily trust others. Indeed, Mr. Okeda is probably smart not to trust the narrator, given how the narrator tried to secretly grope Makiko, but the irony is that by giving the narrator fewer responsibilities, Mr. Okeda gives the narrator more opportunities to see Makiko and Madame Miyagi.



One November day, the narrator attempts to make plans with Makiko to meet up in the evening. But as they're making plans, the narrator begins to speak in a way that makes him sound too aroused, and it frightens Makiko away. The narrator goes into the next room, where he finds Madame Miyagi arranging flowers, and she happens to notice that he has an erection. She takes his penis and pulls it out of his clothes.

This passage is one of several in the novel where a man attempts to flirt and instead seems to frighten a woman away. This passage takes the narrator's failure to communicate to the extreme, showing how after his apparent rejection by Makiko, he stumbles almost accidentally into a sexual situation with Madame Miyagi. Like many characters in the story, the narrator seems to be driven by destiny and unable to avoid Miyagi.



Makiko changed clothes for the narrator, but all of a sudden, she walks in on Madame Miyagi still holding the narrator. The narrator calls out to her, wanting to explain that he only ended up in this position with Madame Miyagi by accident. But Madame Miyagi pulls the narrator down, wrapping her legs around him and encouraging him to penetrate her. In the middle of this, the narrator suddenly realizes that Mr. Okeda is watching, focusing not on him and Madame Miyagi but on Makiko watching him and Madame Miyagi.

This passage reveals that the narrator could have potentially formed a relationship with Makiko, but his inability to control his own lust for Madame Miyagi ruined this possibility. As a silent observer, Mr. Okeda is like a reader, getting more invested in the drama of how Makiko feels than he is by the narrator's betrayal of his trust.



Eventually, the narrator realizes that Mr. Okeda has no intention to interrupt and that he just wants to pretend like what he saw didn't happen. The narrator feels he's in a complicated situation because Makiko has assumed he is Madame Miyagi's lover, while Madame Miyagi has gotten the idea that the narrator actually loves Makiko. The narrator moans Makiko's name in Madame Miyagi's ear, thinking of the falling ginkgo leaves.

The ending of this story fragment ties all the different types of beauty together, melding Makiko, Madame Miyagi, and the ginkgo leaves into one. By trying to have everything, the narrator ends up with nothing, illustrating the consequences of following lust.



CHAPTER 9

Your plane lands before you can finish *On the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon*. While you're going through airport security, someone confiscates your **book**, saying it's banned in Ataguitania. In the airport, however, you meet a fellow traveler, a woman named Corinna who looks a lot like Lotaria, and she tells you she has her own copy of the book she can lend you at some point. But when you look at Corinna's book, you see it's actually *Around an empty grave* by Calixto Bandera. She explains it's just a fake dust jacket.

In Chapter 8, Flannery said he would send the Reader to South America and maybe send Ludmilla's sister, as well, to keep the Reader busy. This passage seems to confirm that Flannery got his wish, although the confusion over whether Corinna is really Ludmilla adds some ambiguity. While several of the story fragments have dealt with the theme of government oppression, the airport security staff confiscating books shows how oppression is beginning to creep into the frame story.



You tell Corinna that if the **book's** dust jacket is a fake, the text is probably fake too. She admits that falsifications can be hard to stop—in Ataguitania, everything can be faked. All of sudden, while Corinna and you are waiting for a taxi, some police officers arrest the two of you. Corinna remains calm, claiming that she is Gertrude and that the cops need to take her to their headquarters at once. You are amazed, and so Corinna tells you that these cops are fake too.

You end up in a station, where Corinna gives her name as Ingrid. Eventually, Corinna gets separated from you, and when she comes back, she's in uniform and another officer calls her Alfonsina. Corinna explains that there's a complicated situation of revolutionaries and counterrevolutionaries in the country, and you may be taken to prison, but it will be a fake prison.

Corinna claims to be a real revolutionary infiltrating the ranks of false revolutionaries. You still worry about going to prison, but Corinna assures you it's a good prison with a library. In addition, a prison can be the best place to find banned **books**. Your quest to come to Ataguitania to find a counterfeiter seems to be derailed. You wonder to yourself if Corinna is actually Lotaria or if she's just someone who fills a similar role in the story.

In prison, you make a complaint at the library about the **book** *Around an empty grave* by Calixto Bandera. The man at the desk says he'd like to perform a test to compare your impressions of the book to the results of a computer. He calls for the programmer, Sheila, and Corinna comes out, answering to yet another name.

While Corinna (as Sheila) is helping to set up the reading experiment, you grab her by the wrist and accuse her of being Lotaria. She claims that she doesn't understand what you're talking about. You accuse her whole revolution of just reproducing old forms of power, saying that whenever she takes off her uniform, there's always another uniform underneath.

Although Marana is initially nowhere to be found in Ataguitania (a fictional country), his presence seems to be everywhere, embodied by all the fakes. The Reader struggles to maintain any grasp on reality as Corinna turns out to possibly be someone else. Although Ataguitania takes things to the extreme, it represents how even in real-world countries the truth can be a difficult concept to pin down.



Corinna keeps changing identities, representing how it is difficult to ever truly know a person because they can contain so many sides. Although Corinna tries to reassure the Reader by telling him that he's only going to a fake prison, this passage raises the question of whether a "fake" prison is any better than a legitimate prison—and raises the larger question of whether the revolutionaries are any different from the counterrevolutionaries if they both use similar tactics.



As the Reader spends more time in Ataguitania, he finds it increasingly difficult to determine what's true, including whether or not he should trust Corinna. The Reader learns the danger of taking Marana's way of thinking too far, realizing that once one begins to question the truth of some things, it can lead to an endless cycle of questioning reality.



Corinna's connection to the computer programmer is yet another clue about her connection to Lotaria (who also uses a computer to analyze books). This passage hints at how "scientific" processes like this computer test of a book can be used to justify oppression by giving it false credibility.



The Reader's inability to find the truth makes him question whether all political ideologies are the same, leading to the same forms of repression. This illustrates the consequences of following Marana's thinking to its logical extreme, and how it can cause a person to doubt everything around them. While this chapter does explore how oppression can take on many forms within different ideologies, it does not necessarily suggest that all political ideologies are the same—just that it might seem that way to someone as jaded about the concept of truth as Marana.



Corinna seems to challenge you, so you rip off her clothes, seeing under the outfit of Sheila the outfits of Alfonsina, Ingrid, and Gertrude, until at last you just see a naked body. She asks if her body is a uniform and then asserts that in fact it is. She begins undressing you. The narrator asks you what right you have to start getting naked with Corinna/Lotaria—wasn't Ludmilla enough for you?

Just then someone takes a photo, and a photographer accuses Captain Alexandra—Corinna—of attempting to have sex with a prisoner again. You and Corinna get up and compose yourselves, returning to the experiment. You get the sense that Corinna is nervous and that somehow the text by Calixto Bandera that she's trying to pull up on the computer has gotten scrambled.

The way that the Reader semi-accidentally starts having sex with Corinna recalls the scene in the previous story fragment between the narrator and Madame Miyagi. Just as that narrator's lust caused him to lose Makiko, the Reader seems to be in danger of losing Ludmilla due to his own lust.



Also like the scene between the previous narrator and Madame Miyagi, the Reader gets interrupted in the middle of sex with Corinna. At the time this novel was written, computers were new, cutting-edge technology—and yet for all their advancements, they seem to be just as capable of errors as traditional books.



AROUND AN EMPTY GRAVE

The narrator, who is called Nacho in this story, sees vultures rise and believes that means the night is almost over. His father, Don Anastasio Zamora, gave the narrator instructions that when he died, the narrator was supposed to go to a place called Oquedal. As the father dies, he tells the narrator that his mother, whom the narrator has never met, is at Oquedal. But the father dies before he can give the mother's name.

The narrator begins his journey to Oquedal. When he arrives, he tells an old American Indian man there that he's the son of Don Anastasio Zamora. The old man points him toward the nicest house in the village. At the lavish house, he meets Anacleto Higuera, an American Indian woman who seems to be his mother (although she won't admit it directly) and offers him a big meal. She has a daughter named Amaranta and a dead brother named Faustino Higuera.

The narrator compares his features against Amaranta's, since she seems to be his sister. In the process, he grabs Amaranta tightly. She squirms away, insulting him. Anacleto comes over and accuses the narrator of being just like Don Anastasio Zamora. The narrator asks what's wrong. He asks if Amaranta is just a random woman, trying to make Anacleto finally say definitively that Amaranta is his sister (and so Anacleto is his mother). Anacleto refuses to confirm anything. Instead, she says the narrator should go to see a woman named Doña Jazmina. She also reveals that the narrator's full name is Nacho Zamora y Alvarado.

Fittingly, after the previous chapter, this story fragment involves a narrator who is trying to find the truth but struggles to do so. The story revolves around the seemingly simple question of who the narrator's mother is, but as it goes on, it becomes clear that just as it was difficult to pin down Corinna's true name and identity, it is also difficult to determine who is the narrator's mother.



The narrator's quest to find his mother begins simply enough, with him easily finding the village where she lives. But although Anacleto acts in a motherly way, offering the narrator food, she won't admit that she is actually his mother.



While other characters in the novel use sex to metaphorically search for the truth, Nacho tries to use sex in a much more literal attempt to find the truth (presumably hoping that Anacleto is his real mother and that she'll stop Nacho from having sex with Amaranta to prevent incest). Interestingly, Nacho's attempts to find his mother cause the other characters to see him like his father, providing an early hint of how Nacho will struggle to escape his father's shadow



The narrator goes to see the Alvarados and finds Doña Jazmina, who is also American Indian. Jazmina tells the narrator about how his father, Don Anastasio Zamora, used to be a big gambler and have affairs with many women. The narrator happens to notice a young woman named Jacinta who is Jazmina's daughter and who looks a lot like Amaranta.

The situation with Doña Jazmina and Jacinta recalls the earlier one with Anacleta and Amaranta (another mother–daughter pair with similar names). It's implied that Don Anastasio Zamora may be the father of both daughters. This means that Nacho's own resemblance to Amaranta doesn't tell him anything about his mother, since he also resembles Jacinta, and so either of their mothers could be his.



Shortly after the narrator and Jacinta are alone, they start trying to have sex. But Doña Jazmina interrupts, telling the narrator that what he's doing is wrong. The narrator again tries ask if that's because Jazmina is his mother, but Jazmina claims his mother is Anacleta. Then she kicks him out of her house.

Nacho seems to be caught in an impossible situation, where Anacleta claims his mother is Doña Jazmina, and Doña Jazmina claims his mother is Anacleta. This is yet another example in the story of an argument between opposite but equivalent forces, like the revolutionaries and counterrevolutionaries.



The narrator goes back to Anacleta. She admits that Don Anastasio Zamora and a man named Faustino Higuera had a competition over her, and it ended up with Faustino dead. But the narrator's father (who was also called Nacho back then), had to leave town shortly afterward. Although Faustino was buried, his grave later appeared empty, sparking rumors that somehow Faustino was still riding around.

The fact that Nacho and his father even went by the same name suggest how Nacho is fated to repeat his father's mistakes. Don Anastasio's lust and impulsiveness led him to father Nacho in the first place, and this seemingly dooms Nacho to continue the cycle and live a life similar to his father.



The narrator goes to see the empty grave. As he's walking, a man wearing a poncho and carrying a blade comes up behind him. He says that he's Faustino Higuera and that he doesn't like the way that the narrator touched his sister. The narrator grabs Faustino's knife and prepares to fight back.

Like most story fragments in the novel, this one raises more questions than it answers. It's possible that "Faustino Higuera" is a son of Anacleta's with the same name as her brother—the man references Nacho touching his sister, and Nacho touched Amaranta, not Anacleta (the sister of the original Faustino Higuera). Alternatively, it's possible that Faustino Higuera did indeed rise from the grave, but he has mistaken Nacho for his father (since Nacho resembles his father, Don Anastasio Zamora, who did indeed touch Anacleta). The ending of this story further illustrates how difficult it is to discover the truth.



CHAPTER 10

The Ataguitanian police let you go on the condition that you agree to go to a foreign country to help them with a secret mission. This is how you end up in the country of Ircania drinking tea with Arkadian Porphyrich, director of the State Police Archives. Arkadian Porphyrich explains that police have similar goals around the world, and so even police of rival nations sometimes collaborate.

Ataguitania and Ircania are rival nations, and yet the Reader experiences them as similar and equally repressive. Ultimately, what connects these different ideologies is authoritarianism, the belief that people should be obedient to authority.



Arkadian Porphyrich believes that police states hold the written word in the highest regard because they go through such great efforts to ban **books**. He explains that banned books are such powerful symbols that there are secret treaties in place for exporting books banned in one country to another country, and vice versa.

Arkadian Porphyrich talks about his belief in the Spirit, which involves serving in the police force, supporting the State, and enacting censorship. Although some of these words disturb you, you are reassured when you find out that Arkadian Porphyrich still enjoys reading outside of work. You bring up the conspiracy about apocrypha you've been hearing about (involving Hermes Marana). Arkadian Porphyrich is familiar with it, but he and his team have never been able to find the mysterious woman who seems to be at the heart of the conspiracy (likely Ludmilla).

You offer Arkadian Porphyrich a copy of *Around an empty grave* by Calixto Bandera as a contribution to his banned **books** exchange program. Arkadian Porphyrich says he'll look into it. In the meantime, there is a very important banned book called *What story down there awaits its end* by Anatoly Anatolin that the police are planning to confiscate.

You decide to contact Anatoly Anatolin first to get his **book** before the police can confiscate it. That night, you dream about seeing Ludmilla on a **train**. You get up the next morning and wait on a park bench for Anatolin to arrive. A young man with a blond beard—Anatolin—arrives and warns you that the park might be under surveillance. Anatolin manages to slip you some papers, but as he reaches into his pocket to get more, two agents dressed in civilian clothes pop out of the hedges to arrest him.

WHAT STORY DOWN THERE AWAITS ITS END?

The narrator walks through a part of a city called the Prospect, only paying attention to the things that interest him. He thinks of his friend Franziska and hopes to meet her on his walk by accident, since he likes being with her but would never want the pressure of a committed relationship.

Arkadian Porphyrich's comments are darkly humorous—he believes that the people who ban books see them as more powerful than, for example, someone like Irnerio, who likes the exterior of books but doesn't care about the contents. The secret trading of banned books between countries shows how books can actually take on more power after being banned, but it also suggests that perhaps oppressive governments can still find ways to harness this power for their own uses.



The Spirit is a stand-in for authoritarianism or perhaps specifically fascism (which, like the Spirit, combines strict standards of obedience with nationalism and forced devotion to a state). Interestingly, despite Arkadian Porphyrich represents how these dark ideas can take on a genial appearance, with his tea-drinking and his interest in reading disguising how oppressive his beliefs are.



Initially, Arkadian Porphyrich's hospitality seems to intrigue the Reader, showing how ideas like fascism and authoritarianism can be seductive. But Arkadian Porphyrich's discussion of confiscating a book begins to puncture his illusion of friendliness.



Once again, an element from several of the story fragments bursts into the Reader's "real" world, with secret agents disrupting the Reader's exchange with Anatoly. The exchange between Anatoly and the Reader dramatizes how censorship and government oppression can interfere with the relationship between author and reader.



The narrator seems to have a godlike control over the world, so he starts making things he doesn't like disappear. He starts by getting rid of public buildings, government employees, and police stations. When he realizes he's accidentally gotten rid of firefighters and postal carriers, he abolishes fires and mail too. He continues to get rid of government structures before going on to dismantle economic ones. Then he gets rid of nature itself, until the Prospect is just a deserted plain.

As the narrator walks, he finally sees Franziska. But as he walks toward her, men in overcoats and hats block his way. The narrator is surprised, because he figured he would have erased all men like them. The men congratulate the narrator, greeting him as one of their own, since they can also erase parts of the world. The narrator wants to go back and un-erase the parts of the world he recently erased, but he finds that he can't.

A crack opens in the earth between the narrator and Franziska, and it begins to widen. The men in hats, who seem to be from something called Section D, congratulate the narrator on his work so far. The narrator tries to get away from them and approach Franziska, but now a whole chasm separates the two of them. From across the way, Franziska smiles, greeting the narrator as she always does when they meet randomly. She says she knows a café nearby where music plays and asks if the narrator will invite her to go there.

The narrator of this story is like an author, who can also decide, by deleting a sentence, to make whole parts of a story's world disappear. Like the Reader, this narrator wants to get rid of government oppression, but he finds that it's not so simple and that when you try to get rid of the unpleasant parts of being human, you might accidentally erase the worthwhile parts as well.



Like Anatolin, the supposed author of this fragment, the narrator faces oppressive forces bigger than himself. The ability of the men in overcoats to erase parts of the world in a way that's permanent has clear parallels with censorship. Like editing, censorship can also remove parts of books—but in a way that the author is powerless to reverse.



The gulf in the earth represents several things, like how censorship makes it difficult for an author to communicate with an audience. It also continues the theme of men looking at women from a distance. The narrator's inability to simply invite Franziska to a café parallels the Reader's struggle to communicate with Ludmilla about his feelings, even after the two of them have had sex.



CHAPTER 11

The narrator tells you that your journey is almost over. You finally get some free time, so you put in requests at the library for all the **books** you haven't finished. But no one at the library can locate the books. You get jealous of all the other readers with their books.

Suddenly one of the other readers seems to address you and tells you his theory of the best way to read. Six more readers speak up, each giving academic-sounding theories of reading. Finally, it's your turn to speak, and you say that you just enjoy reading books from beginning to end without any particular theory. However, recent circumstances have made it impossible for you to complete a book lately.

The penultimate chapter of the book seems to offer the possibility of closure, including the idea that the Reader might finish all the fragments that he started. But once again, he is thwarted. The Reader jealously begins to believe that other readers are having more complete experiences and that he alone struggles to complete a story, but this chapter will challenge that idea.



Each of the readers in this chapter bears some resemblance to Lotaria, the book's foremost overanalytical reader. Lotaria (and her equivalent, Corinna) have led the Reader astray, causing him to forget his love for Ludmilla and her more straightforward way of reading. By wanting to get back to reading from beginning to end, the Reader expresses a desire to get back to Ludmilla.



The fifth reader brings up the *Arabian Nights*, saying that the situation you are in reminds him of it, and he asks permission to tell everyone a story he may have dreamed. He tells about the Caliph Harun-al-Rashid, who sneaks out one night disguised as a merchant when he has insomnia. He ends up losing a game of chance to a maiden that involves seven white pearls and one black pearl. Harun-al-Rashid's punishment for drawing the black pearl is that he has to kill Harun-al-Rashid. Still in disguise, he accepts his punishment to kill himself, but he asks first to hear what the woman's grudge against the Caliph is.

The seven white pearls and one black pearl align with how the Reader feels like the outcast in the middle of a circle of seven other readers who seem to mostly agree with each other. Harun-al-Rashid's punishment for drawing the black pearl is that he must kill himself, perhaps suggesting how the Reader's quests to follow Marana and find the truth have ultimately been self-destructive. Harun-al-Rashid is so curious to learn about the woman's grudge that he is willing to give up his own life to hear about it, illustrating the powerful effects of curiosity (which is also what motivated the Reader).



The fifth reader's story also gets interrupted. He doesn't know what his story is called, so you title it after the last words of the story that the fifth reader spoke: *He asks anxious to hear the story* (referring to the Caliph anxious to hear the story of why the woman wanted to kill him).

The Reader's choice for the final title is significant: while He asks anxious to hear the story refers to the Caliph, it also describes the Reader himself. Just as in his diary, Flannery mused about Mohammad's scribe finishing the last lines of the Koran, the Reader is the one who provides the last title of the novel.



The sixth reader asks to hear all of the titles of the books you haven't been able to find endings for. You read the list in order: *If on a winter's night a traveler, outside the town of Malbork, leaning from the steep slope without fear of wind or vertigo, looks down in the gathering shadow in a network of lines that enlase, in a network of lines that intersect, on the carpet of leaves illuminated by the moon around an empty grave— What story down there awaits its end?—he asks, anxious to hear the story.* The sixth reader believes he knows a novel that begins this way.

On the one hand, this passage suggests that the story fragments are more related than the narrator realized: when you put all their titles together, it forms a sentence. But on the other hand, this connection only deepens the mystery, presenting what seems to be the opening lines of a totally new story. The Reader learns that it's possible to find connections even in a modern world where the truth is fragmented, but he also learns that he may never receive the closure he's looking for.



You try to explain that the list you have written down is just a list of titles, not part of a book. The seventh reader questions whether stories really have beginnings and endings, as you, the Reader, expect. In ancient times, stories could only end two ways, with a hero and heroine ending or with them both dying. As soon as you hear this, you decide you have to marry Ludmilla.

The ending of this chapter reflects on what role stories play in society and why they have existed for so long. This passage explores how individual stories may have beginnings and endings, but they also make up fragments in a larger human tradition of storytelling that doesn't have a clear beginning or end. While it is possible to interpret this moment as an epiphany for the Reader, it actually seems that the Reader is rejecting new knowledge, choosing instead to limit himself to a conventional happy story ending. The novel doesn't settle on whether this is a good thing, including whether the Reader is living an illusion or whether he has made a healthy choice to avoid overanalyzing things.



CHAPTER 12

You and Ludmilla are married. You lie in a double bed that holds your parallel readings. She wants to turn off the light, but you tell her to wait because you're just about to finish your **book**, *If on a winter's night a traveler* by Italo Calvino.

If on a winter's night a traveler is a very unconventional novel, so it's funny that it has the most conventional ending of all: a happy Still, despite the neatness of the ending, the previous chapters suggest both that many people will not find the mutual understanding that the Reader and Ludmilla do, and that future failures to communicate may threaten the Reader and Ludmilla's period of bliss.





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